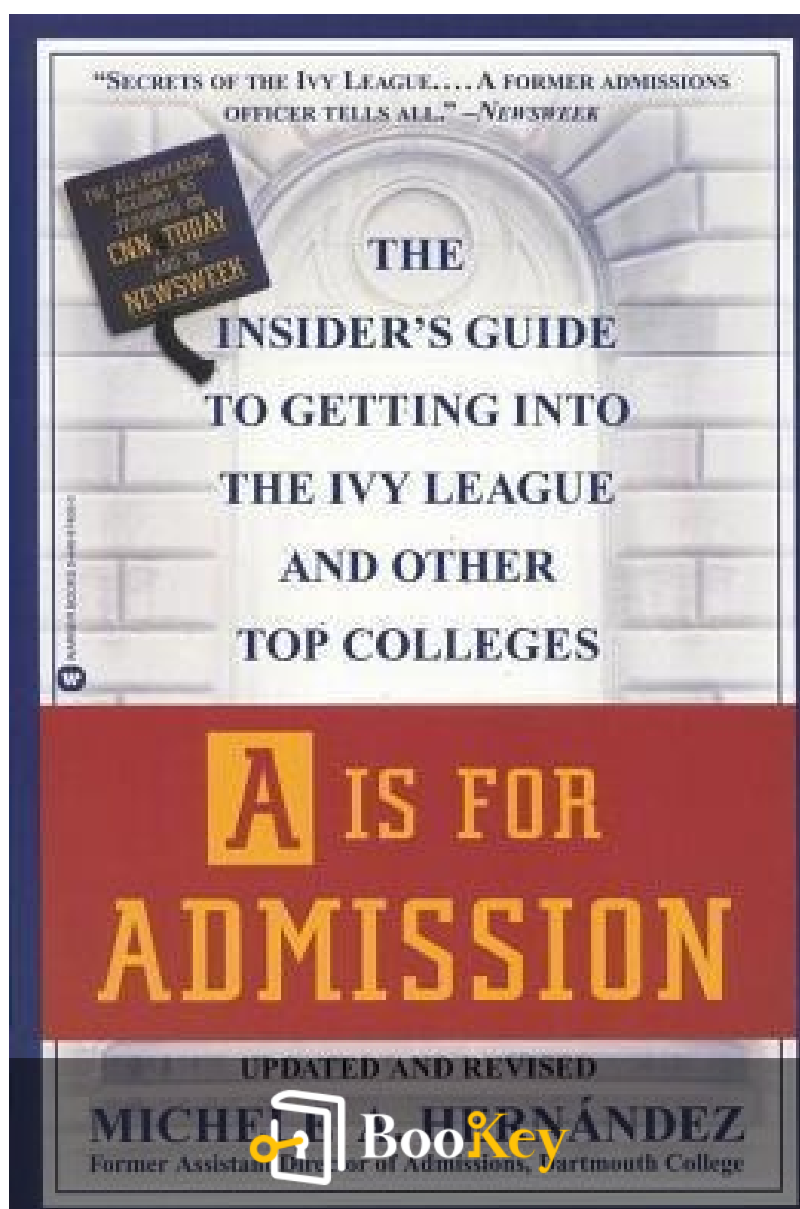


A is for Admission PDF

Michele A. Hernández



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Unlocking the Secrets of Elite College Admissions.

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About the book

In "A is for Admission," Michele A. Hernández, a former admissions officer at Dartmouth College, offers an insider's perspective on the decision-making processes of the most elite educational institutions. She uncovers the strategies and criteria used by these selective schools, providing invaluable insights for students and parents navigating the complex landscape of college admissions.

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About the author

Michele A. Hernández is a renowned educational consultant and author, best known for her incisive work on college admissions and the competitive landscape of higher education. With a unique blend of personal experience and professional insight, Hernández provides valuable guidance for students and families navigating the often daunting college admissions process. A former Dartmouth College admissions officer, she leverages her insider knowledge to demystify the application journey and offer practical strategies for success. Her book, "A is for Admission," reflects her commitment to helping prospective college students understand the nuances of gaining admission to elite institutions, making her a trusted voice in the realm of educational advocacy and mentorship.

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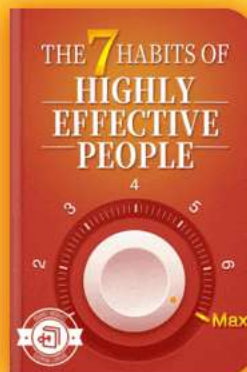
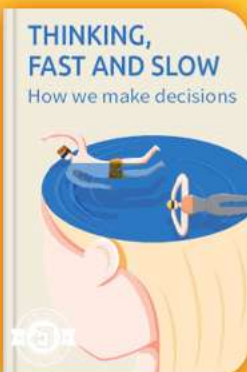


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Adjustments

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Chapter 1 Summary : 1. The Target Audience



Section	Summary
The Target Audience	The understanding of who reads applications is important; assumptions about Ivy League admissions officers' education levels may be incorrect.
The Typical Admissions Officer	Admissions officers fall into two categories: Recent Graduates, who are more relatable to current student experiences, and Lifers, who may rely on outdated formulas and miss potential candidates.
The Implications	Admissions officers often skim applications and may overlook significant details, potentially misjudging a candidate's potential.
What Can You Do?	Be explicit in your application about your achievements and avoid modesty that could lead to misinterpretation of your qualifications.
The Money Question	Wealth can negatively affect Ivy League admissions; officers may prefer candidates from humble backgrounds demonstrating resilience.
Application Presentation Tips	Be vague about family occupations to avoid high expectations and avoid showcasing privilege, focusing instead on modesty and intellectual merits.

The Target Audience

Understanding who will read your application is crucial.

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Many applicants assume that Ivy League admissions officers are exceptionally educated individuals. However, this is often not the case.

The Typical Admissions Officer

Admissions offices generally consist of two types of officers:

1. Recent Graduates

These officers are typically bright, people-oriented, and eager to gain experience before moving on to teaching or graduate programs. They are more in tune with current student dynamics and tend to evaluate candidates more positively due to their recent experiences in higher education.

2. Lifers

This group includes career admissions staff who may lack recent student interactions and insights into contemporary applicant trends. They often rely on established formulas for evaluation and might overlook great candidates because of their biases or lack of awareness of current academic potentials.

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The Implications

Admissions officers often read applications quickly and may miss key details due to exhaustion or lack of expertise. An example illustrates how subtle nuances in a candidate's background can be misinterpreted, leading to a poor assessment of their potential.

What Can You Do?

- Be direct in your recommendations and application. Highlight accomplishments explicitly to avoid any ambiguity about your capabilities.
- Avoid being overly modest or subtle, which may lead to misunderstandings about your qualifications.

The Money Question

Contrary to popular belief, wealth and privilege can be negative factors in Ivy League admissions. They tend to favor candidates from humble backgrounds who demonstrate resilience and determination. Admissions officers may express bias against students from affluent families,

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especially if they perceive a lack of initiative.

Application Presentation Tips

- When filling out information about your family background, consider being vague about occupation to avoid setting high expectations that may not be met.
 - Avoid boasting about privilege, as admissions officers often have preconceived notions that may affect their judgment.
- While some exceptions exist for high-profile applicants, the typical advice for most students is to present themselves modestly and focus on their intellectual merits. A constructive timetable for preparation can be beneficial, especially for those without access to knowledgeable college counseling.

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Example

Key Point: Understanding the admissions officer's perspective can significantly impact your application strategy.

Example: Imagine you are crafting your college application, aware that the person reviewing it might be a recent graduate who just left an Ivy League campus filled with excitement and fresh ideas. You prioritize clearly presenting your achievements and unique experiences, knowing this officer can relate to your journey and enthusiasm. Alternatively, consider the possibility that your application could also be evaluated by a seasoned admissions officer, a career 'lifer,' who might adhere to conventional standards and overlook your innovative approach. Realizing this duality in your audience encourages you to articulate your background effectively, ensuring your application resonates with both types of officers and avoids misinterpretation.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The Composition of Admissions Officers Affects Evaluation Processes

Critical Interpretation: The chapter highlights the diverse backgrounds and experiences of admissions officers, suggesting that their perspectives significantly shape the evaluation of applicants. This contention raises questions about the fairness of the admissions process, where recent graduates may overlook traditional metrics of success, while tenured staff might adhere rigidly to outdated standards. Critics might argue that the author implies an overly simplistic dichotomy that neglects the complexity and variability among individual officers' evaluations. For instance, research from organizations like the National Association for College Admission Counseling reveals that diverse experiences among admissions staff can indeed impact decisions, yet does not definitively correlate with the biases suggested. This invites readers to consider whether a reliance on anecdotal evidence is appropriate in evaluating such a high-stakes process.

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Chapter 2 Summary : 2. The Timetable Through High School: Is Kindergarten Too Early?



2 The Timetable Through High School: Is Kindergarten Too Early?

Overview of Early Education

Many parents believe that admission to prestigious nursery schools or kindergartens is essential for future college success. This perspective leads to an early and intense competition, as illustrated by discussions among parents even for children as young as 18 months. However, the author

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argues that intellectual stimulation at home is more valuable than attending elite schools. Young children can thrive through home learning and a love of reading, often developing strong academic skills outside of competitive school environments.

Middle School/Junior High

Parents should encourage their children to enroll in honors courses to maintain competitiveness in high school. College admissions consider not just grades but the rigor of a student's course load relative to their peers. High schools categorize courses differently, impacting how admissions officers assess applicants. It is crucial to start strong in high school, as reputations established in early grades can influence later academic opportunities.

Challenges for Shy Students

Shy students need to actively work on their participation in class to make a positive impression on teachers. Engaging in activities like public speaking can help improve confidence. Teachers often discuss student participation, which affects recommendations, meaning students must learn to contribute

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to discussions even if they are quiet.

Avoiding Grade Grubbing

Students should focus on learning rather than just improving grades. Behaviors such as 'grade grubbing' can negatively affect a student's reputation, as admissions officers prefer candidates who show genuine interest in learning. Striving for an engaged academic life is more valuable than merely seeking high grades for college admission.

Preparing for Standardized Testing

Starting from ninth grade, students should plan for SAT Subject Tests in addition to the SAT Reasoning Test. Familiarity with the test format through preparation can significantly impact scores. It's recommended to take Subject Tests immediately after relevant coursework is completed.

High School Academic Planning

Freshman Year

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- Enroll in advanced classes and participate in academic discussions.
- Engage in extracurricular activities thoroughly.
- Establish strong study habits early on and prioritize reading.

Sophomore Year

- Continue reading diverse materials and take practice tests.
- Assess strengths and explore new interests while maintaining commitments.

Junior Year

- Focus on achieving top grades and take the PSAT and SAT/ACT tests seriously.
- Start visiting colleges and engage in academic interests outside classroom requirements.

Senior Year

- Maintain high grades, especially in the spring.
- Stay organized with college applications and deadlines.
- Be proactive in submitting standardized test scores and finalizing application essays.

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Standardized Test Prep Courses

The effectiveness of prep courses varies, influenced by individual motivation and study habits. While some may benefit from structured classes, others might find independent study adequate. Familiarity with the SAT helps improve scores, but high reading comprehension from extensive reading is crucial for excelling in the critical reading section.

Conclusion

Colleges emphasize holistic assessment in admissions, valuing academic rigor, genuine interest in learning, and active classroom participation. Parents and students should prioritize intellectual engagement over mere academic accolades to foster a strong foundation for college readiness.

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Example

Key Point:Intellectual engagement is more important than merely attending elite schools.

Example:Imagine you are a parent standing in a playground, discussing nursery school options with other parents, each more anxious than the last about securing a spot in the best preschool. Despite the competition, reflect on a moment at home when you read together with your child, noticing their eyes light up with curiosity as they ask questions about the story. This experience demonstrates that the love for learning cultivated at home is irreplaceable and sets a strong academic foundation, proving that navigating early education should focus more on stimulating intellect than the prestige of the institutions.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Rethinking Early Education and Admissions Pressure

Critical Interpretation: The chapter argues that the competitive race for prestigious early education can be misguided, emphasizing that intellectual stimulation at home might outperform elite schooling in developing critical learning skills. While the author suggests home learning as a preferable alternative, readers should question this stance by considering research that depicts the advantages of structured early education in developing social skills and foundational academic knowledge (see Reardon, S. F. (2011). 'The widening academic achievement gap between the rich and poor: New evidence and possible explanations.'). A one-size-fits-all approach may overlook the unique needs of diverse learners.

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Chapter 3 Summary : 3. Early-Decision and Early-Action Policies

Section	Summary
Overview of Early Application Options	Early decision applications are binding, while early action applications are nonbinding, both enhancing chances of Ivy League admissions.
Changes in Early Policies	In 2006, Harvard, Princeton, and UVA ended early admissions, causing students to hesitate on early applications to keep regular decision options open.
Application Trends	Post-policy changes saw a rise in early-action applications, while early-decision applications at Ivies remained stable, with some schools like Stanford and Yale adopting restrictive early-action policies.
Advantages of Applying Early	Early-decision applicants usually have higher acceptance rates; however, they need to be certain about their first-choice college.
Differences in Applicant Pools	The early-decision pool tends to be more homogeneous, as top candidates often prefer to compare financial aid offers instead of committing early.
Institutional Benefits of Early Decision	Colleges gain strong yield rates and diverse classes, and early applicants often contribute positively to alumni engagement.
Possible Outcomes for Early Applications	Early applicants can be accepted, deferred, or rejected, with deferred students needing to actively engage with admissions for potential reconsideration.
Steps After Being Deferred	Deferred students should contact admissions for feedback, reaffirm interest, and share relevant updates without overwhelming with information.
Financial Aid Considerations	Early applications generally do not influence financial aid packages, treating early and regular applicants equally.
Conclusion	Early decision is beneficial for certain students but requires careful consideration for those exploring multiple colleges with merit-based aid.

Early-Decision and Early-Action Policies

Overview of Early Application Options

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Applying early decision or early action can enhance your chances of admission into Ivy League schools. Early decision applications are binding (commit to attending if accepted), while early action applications are nonbinding (no commitment required).

Changes in Early Policies

In 2006, Harvard, Princeton, and the University of Virginia discontinued their early admissions policies, leading to a shift in application trends. The “Harvard/Princeton effect” caused students to hesitate applying early to maintain options for regular decision admissions.

Application Trends

Following these changes, early-action applications surged at several universities. while early-decision applications

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Chapter 4 Summary : 4. The New SAT and the ACT and Recentering

The New SAT and the ACT and Recentering

Overview of SAT Changes

This chapter discusses the dramatic changes in the SAT and its implications due to "recentering." It highlights how the SAT's scoring system has evolved and how these changes affect highly selective college admissions.

Historical Context of SAT Scores

Originally, the SAT median score was set at 500 for both verbal and math sections. Over the years, the demographics of test-takers shifted, leading to different median scores: 428 for verbal and 482 for math by 1995. This demographic change has rendered comparisons between old and new scores unreliable.

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Score Distribution Inequities

The distribution of scores on the old SAT resulted in many students being crowded into mid-range scores. For instance, only 1 percent scored over 700 on the verbal section, and a large portion scored below 500. The scoring mechanism was flawed, leading to inconsistencies and unfairness, especially at the extremes of the score range.

Recentering of SAT Scores

In 1995, the College Board adjusted the scoring to establish a true median at 500 for both verbal and math sections, restoring a bell curve distribution. This adjustment meant that the old and new scores cannot be directly compared, necessitating conversion tables published by College Board to provide equivalent scores.

Impact on College Admissions

The recentering significantly altered the landscape of college admissions, particularly for selective schools like Dartmouth. The average admitted scores rose, shifting the scoring benchmarks that students and parents previously used to

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evaluate college admissions chances.

Understanding Score Trends

The author encourages readers to be aware that scores now differ significantly from past expectations. Post-2005, the SAT was further modified, including an additional writing section; thus, establishing a perfect score of 2400, thereby changing standards again.

Strategy for SAT Preparation

Students are advised to take the SAT two or three times to familiarize themselves with the format, as repeated attempts can lead to score plateaus. Understanding how scores are presented and perceived by colleges is critical in strategic planning for admissions.

ACT Comparison and Score Choice

The ACT provides students with score choice, allowing them to submit their best results, a feature that attracts many. This section explains how both the SAT and ACT score systems function and how they are perceived in college admissions,

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with their respective strengths and weaknesses discussed.

Concordance between SAT and ACT Scores

The author provides concordance tables mapping ACT scores to SAT equivalents, guiding students in understanding how their scores translate from one test to another.

Conclusion

The chapter emphasizes the evolving nature of standardized testing and its profound implications on college admissions. Students must navigate these changes thoughtfully, opting for the exam that aligns best with their strengths and preparing strategically for optimal outcomes.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The flawed history and evolution of SAT scores reflect deeper inequities in college admissions.

Critical Interpretation: Hernández highlights the issues surrounding the 'recentering' of SAT scores, emphasizing the drastic changes in scoring systems that have occurred over the years. While she presents these shifts as necessary corrections to previous inequities, one might argue that such centralized standardized testing inherently fails to account for the diverse capabilities and backgrounds of students. Academic scholars like James W. McBain in 'The Testing Charade' argue that these standardized tests perpetuate existing societal disparities rather than diminish them. Therefore, readers are encouraged to scrutinize Hernández's perspective and consider broader critiques of standardized testing practices.

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Chapter 5 Summary : 5. The Importance of the SAT Subject Tests

Section	Summary
Importance of SAT Subject Tests	Author argues SAT Subject Tests may be more important than high school transcripts in college admissions.
High School Transcript Limitations	Many high schools do not rank students, leading to potential grade inflation and reliance on standardized test scores.
Comparing Students Across Different Schools	Test scores offer a common metric to evaluate students from various educational backgrounds.
Inconsistency in Teacher Recommendations	Subjective teacher evaluations are variable, making SAT Subject Tests useful for standardized interpretation.
Test Scores as Equalizers	High scores demonstrate academic readiness, while low scores may suggest deficiencies in a student's application.
Strategies for Poor Test-Takers	Students struggling with testing should focus on content knowledge to improve their Subject Test scores.
Weight of Test Scores vs. Recommendations	Admissions officers may prioritize test scores over recommendations in assessing student capabilities.
High Scores and Admission Potential	High test scores tend to outweigh lower grades, influencing Ivy League admissions biases.
Conclusion on Standardized Testing in Admissions	Standardized test scores play a significant role in college admissions, especially in Ivy League contexts.

The Importance of the SAT Subject Tests

The conventional wisdom from admissions officers emphasizes the high school transcript as the most crucial academic component of college applications. However, based on experience in admissions, the author argues that SAT Subject Tests may actually carry greater weight.

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High School Transcript Limitations

Many high schools avoid ranking students, leading to ambiguity in GPA representation. This lack of clarity may result in colleges perceiving inflated grades or hiding information, causing them to rely more heavily on standardized test scores for evaluation.

Comparing Students Across Different Schools

Admissions officers face challenges in evaluating students from schools of varying sizes. Test scores serve as a common metric for comparison, allowing them to assess students who may have different levels of competition in their high schools.

Inconsistency in Teacher Recommendations

The variability in teacher evaluations means that subjective opinions can't always be reliably compared. SAT Subject Tests provide a standardized measure to help admissions officers interpret teacher recommendations more effectively.

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Test Scores as Equalizers

SAT Subject Tests can either validate or contradict other components of an application. High scores signal a student's academic readiness compared to national peers, while lower scores may indicate the opposite.

Strategies for Poor Test-Takers

Students who struggle with testing should prepare thoroughly, as high performance on Subject Tests indicates knowledge of content rather than aptitude. This differentiation is crucial for Ivy League admissions.

Weight of Test Scores vs. Recommendations

Admissions officers may place more significance on test scores than on recommendations, adjusting their perspectives on student capabilities based on these scores.

High Scores and Admission Potential

While Ivy League admissions officers often claim to value holistic assessments, high test scores tend to overshadow

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lower grades. There is a prevailing bias toward students who excel in testing over those who display academic diligence without corresponding test performance.

Conclusion on Standardized Testing in Admissions

Ultimately, despite the admissions rhetoric, standardized test scores significantly impact college admissions decisions. The ensuing chapters will further demonstrate the central role of testing in Ivy League admissions processes.

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Example

Key Point: The SAT Subject Tests can significantly influence college admissions decisions.

Example: Imagine you're applying to your dream college, and while your grades are solid, you notice your high school didn't rank its students. This means your GPA might not fully represent your academic ability to the admissions committee. As you prepare for the SAT Subject Tests, you realize that these standardized scores become a vital aspect of your application, offering a concrete evidence of your knowledge compared to peers nationwide. You study diligently, taking practice tests and honing your skills, knowing that a high score could not only highlight your academic readiness but also elevate your application amidst uncertainties created by your transcript. Understanding this, you're determined to utilize the SAT Subject Tests to show colleges your true capabilities, proving to them that you're not just an average student, but a competitive candidate worthy of admission.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The Author's Position on SAT Subject Tests vs. High School Transcripts

Critical Interpretation: Hernández underscores the importance of SAT Subject Tests in admissions, asserting they surpass transcripts due to their ability to offer standardized benchmarks amidst variations in GPA reporting and school contexts. This perspective, while compelling, invites scrutiny as it suggests a reliance on test scores that could neglect individual student narratives and contexts, potentially reinforcing inequities rather than addressing them. Critics of standardized testing, such as those in the fairTest movement (source: FairTest.org), argue that these tests may not accurately reflect a student's potential or capabilities, highlighting the need to consider more holistic approaches in college admissions.

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Chapter 6 Summary : 6. The Academic Index (AI)

Section	Summary
Chapter Title	Chapter 6: The Academic Index (AI)
Overview	The AI is a formula combining test scores and high school rank into a single score used by Ivy League schools for admissions.
Components of AI	Averages of SAT Reasoning Test scores, SAT Subject Test scores, and Converted Rank Score (CRS).
Historical Context	The AI has been used since the 1950s and became public knowledge through Hernández's book.
AI Calculation	Includes highest SAT scores and CRS derived from class rankings. Example: A student with CRS of 67, SATs averaging 750, and Subject Tests averaging 650 has an AI of 207.
Inequities in AI System	Test scores disproportionately weigh into AI, and CRS calculations vary by school, leading to inconsistencies.
Adjustments and Overrides	Admissions officers can adjust CRS scores based on qualitative information, allowing for context-based overrides.
Ranking Systems	Ivy schools use distinct ranking systems; for instance, Dartmouth uses a 1-9 scale, while others have numeric systems.
Use of AI	Originally for evaluative purposes for athletes, it now serves as a guideline for broader student performance, correlating high scores with increased acceptance rates.
Conclusion for Applicants	Applicants should understand AI components and focus on academic performance, test scores, leadership roles, and personal stories to enhance admission prospects.

Chapter 6: The Academic Index (AI)

In this chapter, Michele A. Hernández provides an in-depth look at the Academic Index (AI), a crucial yet often overlooked aspect of Ivy League admissions. The AI is a formula used exclusively by Ivy League schools, combining a student's test scores and high school rank into a single score

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on a scale from 1 to 240. The AI has been a closely guarded secret, despite its significance in admissions decisions.

Understanding the AI

-

Components of the AI

- The AI is calculated by averaging SAT Reasoning Test scores, SAT Subject Test scores, and the converted rank score (CRS).

- Most institutions assign two ratings for applicants: academic and extracurricular/personal.

-

Historical Context

- The AI became known to the public after the publication of Hernández's book, revealing its persistent use since the

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Chapter 7 Summary : 7. Advanced Placement Scores

7 Advanced Placement Scores

Importance of AP and IB Exams

Scoring well on Advanced Placement (AP) or International Baccalaureate (IB) tests can significantly enhance a student's academic profile, especially for highly selective colleges. These scores, while not factored into the Academic Index (AI) formula, are regarded as better indicators of college-level readiness than SAT Subject Test scores.

Choosing Challenging Curricula

Students should enroll in as many AP or IB courses as their high school offers. These courses indicate a commitment to challenging academic work, which is favorable in college admissions. AP and IB scores are considered highly indicative of a student's ability, with AP scores ranging from

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1 to 5 and IB scores from 1 to 7.

Structure and Assessment of AP Tests

AP tests resemble college-level assessments more than SAT Subject Tests. They require deeper analysis and writing skills rather than rote memorization, allowing advanced students to showcase their abilities effectively. For example, calculus exams demand a demonstration of problem-solving skills, while history tests involve essay writing based on source evaluation.

Impact of AP and IB Scores on College Applications

Strong AP or IB scores, particularly when obtained before senior year, can significantly boost a student's application. Exceptional performance in advanced subjects can shift how admissions officers perceive a student's overall academic strengths, which might otherwise be overshadowed by mediocre standardized test results.

AP Scholar Awards

The College Board awards AP Scholar distinctions based on

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the number of AP exams taken and scores achieved. These awards serve as notable academic accomplishments that can enhance an application. Award levels include AP Scholar, AP Scholar with Honor, AP Scholar with Distinction, AP State Scholar, and National AP Scholar.

Statistics and Application to Admissions

A considerable proportion of students who take AP exams achieve high marks, with a small percentage receiving top-level awards. Such achievements can lead to higher acceptance rates for these students in competitive colleges.

Strategies for AP Score Management

Students can suppress individual AP scores when reporting to colleges, unlike standardized test scores. This ability allows students to take numerous AP tests without fearing low scores will harm their college applications.

Conclusion

Understanding the role of AP and IB tests is crucial as students prepare their college applications. High scores in

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these exams can dramatically enhance a student's academic profile and improve their chances in the competitive admissions landscape.

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Chapter 8 Summary : 8. The Reading Process

8 The Reading Process

Overview of Application Sorting

The chapter outlines the intricate process of how applications are received, sorted, and evaluated in Ivy League admissions offices. After applicants submit their materials, admissions offices receive multiple documents, including student and counselor forms and recommendations, that need to be sorted, filed, and processed. This typically begins with the mail being delivered to admissions offices where a small team sorts and organizes it over several weeks.

Folder Assembly Steps

-

Mail Handling

: Admissions offices receive large amounts of mail daily

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which is sorted and stamped.

-

Data Entry

: System technicians process applicant information, calculate critical statistics, and prepare folders with a master card summarizing each applicant's data.

-

Initial Review

: Folders are first read by regional officers who assess applicants' strengths based on personal impressions, data, and high school context.

Regional Officer Duties

Regional officers visit high schools to promote their college and gather insights. They document their impressions which can influence later evaluations. However, the chapter emphasizes that such visits may not significantly impact admissions decisions.

Evaluation Rankings

Every folder is evaluated with a ranking system based on academics and extracurricular achievements. The initial

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regional readers provide appraisals, which are further assessed in a second reading, often resulting in a recommendation for acceptance or rejection.

Decision Process

-

One-reader A/R System

: Exceptional candidates may skip the committee stage with a "one-reader A," while weak applications might go directly to rejection.

-

Committee Review

: Folders with borderline evaluations undergo committee review, where final decisions are made, often requiring majority agreement.

-

Likely Letters

: Top candidates may receive "likely letters" indicating probable acceptance, serving to entice them towards the institution.

Conclusion

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The admissions process is depicted as systematic and thorough, ensuring checks and balances exist to maintain fairness. It is noted that extraordinary applicants stand out during evaluations, and the process allows for comprehensive assessment while adhering to institutional standards.

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Chapter 9 Summary : 9. A Step-by-Step Look at How Your Application Is Read and a Brief Look at the Common Application

Section	Summary
Overview of the Application Reading Process	Describes how college applications, particularly the Common Application, are meticulously reviewed by admissions officers, focusing on individual assessment rather than idealized composite profiles.
The Common Application	Introduced to streamline applications for multiple colleges, accepted by around 350 colleges, but often includes additional requirements like pre-applications and supplemental essays.
Pre-Application	First document seen in an application folder; collects essential info and application fees, with encouragement for early submissions, especially for early decision applications.
Common Application Pages	Page 1: Personal data and academic interests; students advised to be selective and descriptive. Page 2: High school academic history; important to highlight significant programs and accurately report test scores. Page 3: Family info and academic honors; awards should distinguish applicants in competition. Page 4: Work experiences and personal essay; a strong narrative can help middle-range candidates stand out.
The Importance of the Essay	Crucial for applicants with average grades/scores; admissions officers prefer unique, personal narratives over weak essays.
High School Transcript and Recommendations	Transcripts reveal academic rigor and trends; teacher recommendations are valuable for showing classroom engagement and intellectual curiosity.
Supplemental Materials	Options for arts or athletic supplements can enhance an application if they are impactful.
The Interview Process	Interviews can enhance or challenge perceptions of candidates; they offer a chance to express genuine passions.
Final Thoughts	Students should present a balanced application that showcases their interests and achievements, focusing on intellectual drive, unique contributions, and personal integrity.

Chapter 9: A Step-by-Step Look at How Your

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Application Is Read and a Brief Look at the Common Application

Overview of the Application Reading Process

This chapter provides a detailed account of how college applications, especially the Common Application, are read by admissions officers. It emphasizes that each application is examined thoughtfully rather than creating a composite image of an ideal student.

The Common Application

The Common Application was introduced to simplify the process of applying to multiple colleges. However, around 350 out of several thousand colleges accept it. Many colleges impose additional requirements, such as pre-applications and

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Chapter 10 Summary : 10. A Brief Trip to the Committee

10 A Brief Trip to the Committee

The committee selection process for college admissions omits both exceptionally strong and weak applications early on. Typically, "one-reader A's" (scores 8s and 9s) and "one-reader R's" (scores 1s to 3s) are discarded, as decisions on these are final. The director closely monitors folders and may intervene if a decision remains undecided after initial readings.

Committee Procedures

Folders that pass through an initial review may be assessed by a regional officer for additional comments, while special cases (e.g., recruited athletes, high-need international applicants, and minority students) follow different procedures. By mid-March, the director informs the committee of admit and reject numbers, allowing for a structured selection process. The staff splits into smaller

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committees, each developing its own methodology for reviewing applications involving discussions based on the master card and ready sheet.

Example Cases

Several fictional cases illustrate the committee's deliberations:

Case Number One: Josh

-

Evaluation:

Typical academic profile but lacks leadership and community commitment.

-

Outcome:

Rejected.

Case Number Two: African-American Woman

-

Evaluation:

Adequate rank, but weak course load and extracurriculars.

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-

Outcome:

Rejected despite concerns about minority representation.

Case Number Three: Jesse

-

Evaluation:

Below-average rank but strong enthusiasm and creativity.

-

Outcome:

Accepted for his unique contributions.

Case Number Four: High-Ranking Student

-

Evaluation:

Strong academic performance but lacks compelling personality and engagement.

-

Outcome:

Waitlisted.

Case Number Five: Korean-American Girl

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Evaluation:

Strong academic credentials but fails to stand out and appears overly conventional.

-

Outcome:

Rejected due to lack of distinction.

Conclusion of Committee Process

The committee process focuses on selecting the most qualified students from a large applicant pool, with particular emphasis on distinguishing unique candidates. While some perform well academically, it is the most interesting applicants—those who demonstrate creativity and curiosity—that tend to succeed in gaining admission. Each college has variations of this committee process, but the overarching objective remains consistent across institutions.

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Example

Key Point: Distinction in Application Review

Example: Imagine you're one of many applicants, with solid grades but a conventional profile. To truly secure your spot, you need to highlight what makes you unique and authentic in your application—those qualities that stand out in a sea of qualified candidates and catch the committee's attention.

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Chapter 11 Summary : 11. Flags and Tags: Athletic Recruiting at the Ivy League Schools

11 Flags and Tags: Athletic Recruiting at the Ivy League Schools

Overview of Athletic Recruiting in the Ivy League

The Ivy League institutions utilize a uniform process for recruiting athletes as they are all part of the same athletic league. Unlike smaller colleges, Ivy varsity teams primarily belong to Division I, with the exception of football, which is Division I-AA. Although recruiting is allowed, athletic scholarships are prohibited.

Academic Index (AI) Significance

The AI, developed for athletic purposes, has a cutoff of approximately 169 across all Ivy schools for athletes. Athletes with lower AIs may have to have their applications

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reviewed and justified to the Ivy League deans of admissions, especially for major sports that generate significant revenue, like football and basketball.

Recruiting Process and Coach Involvement

Coaches dedicate substantial time to identifying and recruiting the best athletes by reviewing local sports news and scouting competitions. They aim to find athletes whose academic credentials align with Ivy admissions standards. Coaches communicate with athletes, encouraging them to take standardized tests to qualify for admissions.

Admission Priorities and Lists

Each sport has a specific target number of recruits that varies by college and sport. Higher priority is given to revenue-producing sports, with some institutions having a historical focus on particular sports. Coaches submit confidential lists of potential recruits to athletic liaisons at admissions offices.

Tags and Their Impact

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Recruited athletes receive small tags indicating their status from the admissions office. The impact of these tags varies based on athlete rankings, the importance of their sport, and their academic readiness.

Admissions Decisions and AI Considerations

AI plays a significant role in determining an athlete's admission chances. Coaches' rankings help admissions officers evaluate athletes' potential, along with their academic histories. Factors like course rigor also influence decisions.

Variability in Acceptance Rates

Recruited athletes constitute a small percentage of the applicant pool but are accepted at much higher rates compared to the general applicant body. Despite this, some Ivy schools are stricter than others about recruiting standards.

The Role of Coaches and the Admissions Process

Coaches cannot officially promise admissions but provide insight on recruit rankings. Lists provided by coaches are

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updated frequently based on admissions feedback, affecting a recruit's chances. Moreover, new coaches often need time to adapt to Ivy standards and adjust their recruiting strategies accordingly.

"Squeeze Plays" in Recruiting

When athletes receive admission offers from other colleges, they can execute "squeeze plays" by leveraging these offers to prompt Ivy League admission responses. This process allows for early decision-making, although it does not influence financial aid offers.

Conclusion

The Ivy League's athletic recruiting process is an intricate balance of academic criteria and athletic merit. While athletes bring significant competition to the schools and higher acceptance rates, the challenges of maintaining academic standards within the admissions framework remain ever-present. The relationship between coaches and admissions officers is critical for navigating this complex system.

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Chapter 12 Summary : 12. Flags and Tags: Legacies

12 Flags and Tags: Legacies

Definition of a Legacy

A legacy is typically defined as the child of a graduate from a specific undergraduate institution, such as Dartmouth College. Only parents who attended the college count; grandparents, siblings, and relatives from professional schools do not.

Legacy Acceptance Rates

At highly selective colleges, legacies are accepted at significantly higher rates than non-legacies. For example, Dartmouth has a legacy acceptance rate of approximately 40%, compared to an overall rate of 15–20%. Princeton's legacy rate ranges from 30–40%. Although legacies are favored, 60–70% are still rejected, indicating a competitive

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admission process.

Economic Rationale

Colleges often accept legacies at these heightened rates due to the long-term benefits of fostering loyalty among alumni, which can lead to substantial donations. However, most Ivy League schools are need-blind, meaning acceptance is not based on financial contribution potential.

Historical Context

Efforts to reduce legacy admissions in the late 1960s and early 1970s faced backlash, leading to the continuation of these policies at institutions like Princeton and Yale. Harvard, after experimenting with merit-based admissions, reverted to legacy preferences due to concerns about diversity and donor relations.

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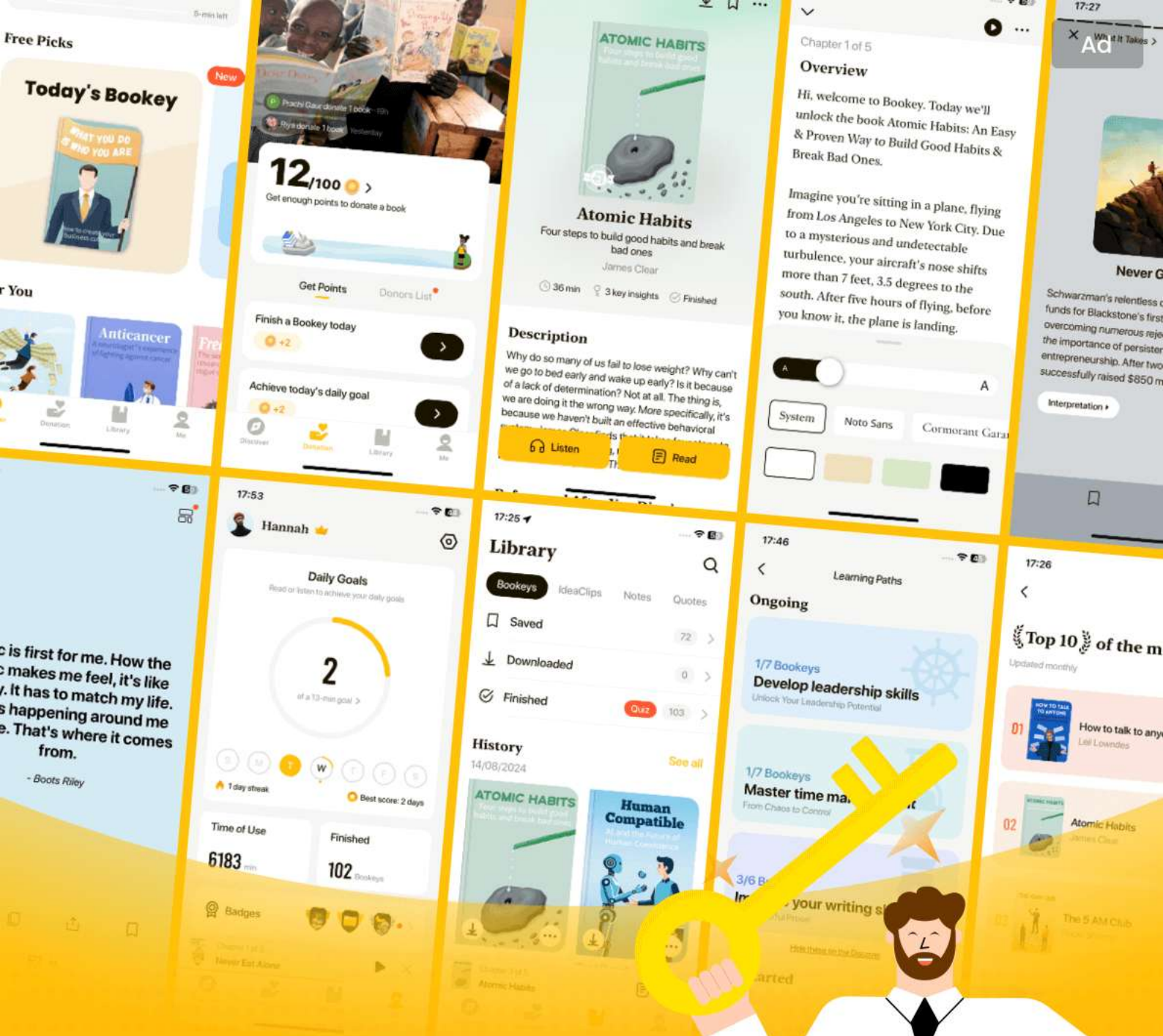
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Chapter 13 Summary : 13. Flags and Tags: Special Talents

Flags and Tags: Special Talents

Importance of Special Talents in Admissions

Ivy League colleges consider special talents like music, dance, and art/photography as part of their admissions process. Each institution uses a unique rating scale for evaluating these talents.

Submission of Talent Materials

Students may submit musical tapes or slides of artwork to showcase their abilities. Materials are typically forwarded to relevant departments for further assessment. It is advisable to send additional materials only if the talent is exceptional and the student intends to pursue that talent in college.

Guidelines for Submitting Additional Materials

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1.

Quality Over Quantity

: Only submit if you are highly skilled; mediocre talents may harm your application.

2.

Department Recommendations

: If a department recommends you, be prepared to engage in related activities if admitted.

3.

Direct Submissions

: Consider sending materials directly to the specific department along with your application details for identification.

Impact of Special Talent Ratings

A positive rating can significantly enhance your application, especially for those at a mid-level academic ranking (5s, 6s, 7s). Top-rated academic applicants (8s, 9s) may find it adds an extra edge, while lower-ranked applicants (1s-3s) may not see much benefit.

Listing Talents vs. Sending Materials

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State any special talents within the application, and it is generally acceptable to do so without providing supplementary materials. Institutions often trust applicants' claims of achievements and experiences. If significant awards are earned, they can be listed under "Special honors or prizes" without needing to submit physical proof.

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Chapter 14 Summary : 14. Flags and Tags: Development/ VIP Cases

Flags and Tags: Development/VIP Cases

Overview of Development in College Admissions

Development refers to significant financial contributions that may influence college admissions, typically in the millions, rather than the smaller yearly donations. A clear connection between a potential donor (like a CEO) and the college's development office can lead to a "development flag" on an applicant's file, indicating their link to the institution.

Impact of Development Flags

Development flags indicate special consideration but do not ensure admission. For instance, at Dartmouth, only about 30 out of over 11,400 applicants were on the full development list, with around one-third being accepted. This reflects a low percentage of incoming freshmen admitted through

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development cases.

Director of Admissions' Role

The director of admissions holds significant power over the consideration of development cases. Despite some schools allowing more development admissions, Dartmouth's admissions approach discourages admitting students who don't meet academic standards.

Wealth and Access in Admissions

Daniel Golden's book, **The Price of Admission**, explores how monetary influence can facilitate admission into elite colleges, highlighting that alumni connections significantly affect admission chances, particularly at institutions like Harvard.

VIP Cases

VIP status is primarily reserved for children of prominent figures, such as political leaders or celebrities. While these cases can bring attention and funding to colleges, they are rare and still undergo regular admissions processes before being finalized by the director of admissions.

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Chapter 15 Summary : 15. Flags and Tags: Faculty and Trustee Recommendations

Flags and Tags: Faculty and Trustee Recommendations

Overview of Faculty and Trustee Flags

Faculty or trustee recommendations can provide additional consideration in the college admissions process, but their impact is limited. Schools like Dartmouth are particularly stringent about these flags, making authentic and strong endorsements essential.

Importance of Genuine Recommendations

A letter from a professor who appreciates your work holds more weight than one from a family friend. While college presidents or influential board members can advocate for students, this rarely sways admissions for weaker candidates.

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Cautions Against Uninformed Recommendations

Applicants should avoid loading their applications with letters from prominent figures who lack personal knowledge of them. Such letters can suggest privilege rather than genuine talent and may harm an applicant's credibility.

Risks of Name-Dropping

Letters from high-profile individuals often lack substantive content regarding the applicant's abilities and can signal insecurity. Relying on academic achievements is more effective than seeking endorsements from well-known figures.

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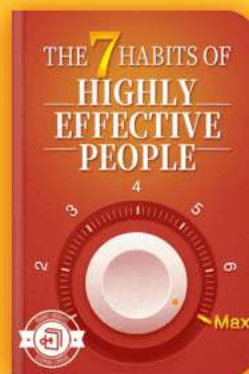
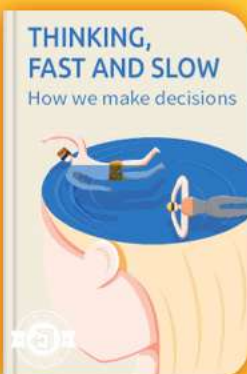


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Chapter 16 Summary : 16. Flags and Tags: Minority Recruiting

Summary of Chapter 16: Flags and Tags: Minority Recruiting

Overview of Minority Recruiting

Minority recruiting in college admissions remains a perplexing issue, historically characterized by a lack of diversity predominantly among Ivy League schools. This chapter clarifies the concept of minority tags and their influence on admissions processes.

Historical Context

Thirty years ago, Ivy League institutions predominantly admitted affluent white males, and feeder schools played a significant role in their demographics. Today, around 60-75% of Ivy students come from public high schools, reflecting a shift toward greater socioeconomic representation.

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Admissions Considerations

Colleges now assess applicants through a socioeconomic lens, offering leniency in standardized test scores for first-generation college students, regardless of race. Efforts are underway to attract low-income students, yet a significant disparity persists between affluent and lower-income student representation.

Definition and Implications of 'Minority' Status

The term 'minority' encompasses underrepresented groups like Black, Hispanic, and sometimes Native American applicants. However, definitions remain ambiguous—many potential minority candidates may not meet the criteria, leading to inclusivity challenges.

Affirmative Action and Diversity

Affirmative action aims to rectify past discrimination, but its application often lacks clarity. While some students benefit from special considerations, the intersection of race, class, and educational history complicates equitable treatment in

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admissions decisions.

Racial Disparities in Admissions

Asian-American applicants often face unique challenges, as their high achievement levels create a competitive disadvantage in Ivy admissions. Although included in "students of color" statistics, they receive no specific advantages, leading to concerns over equity in the admissions process.

Admissions Processes for Minority Applicants

At institutions like Dartmouth, minority applicants enjoy flexible admissions criteria. Admissions officers weigh class rank and test scores differently compared to non-minority candidates. This flexibility often favors minority candidates with lower standardized scores but high class standings.

Case Studies of Minority Applicants

Various examples illustrate the admission process disparities. For instance, applicants with privileged backgrounds may still gain admission based on race, while disadvantaged

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minority candidates can be accepted with lower qualifications due to affirmative action and diversity motivations.

Retention and Recruitment Strategies

Despite variances in qualifications, minority students tend to succeed academically at Ivy schools, with high retention rates. Colleges actively recruit minority students through various outreach programs, but competition remains fierce for a limited pool of qualified candidates.

Conclusion

Ivy League schools continue to grapple with minority recruiting amidst conflicting objectives of diversity, equal opportunity, and the realities of academic standards. The chapter underscores the nuances and complexities in admissions processes that ultimately shape campus demographics.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: The complexities surrounding minority recruiting in college admissions raise questions about true equity.

Critical Interpretation: Hernández highlights that while efforts to recruit minority students are significant, the actual application of these policies can create inequities. For example, the flexible admissions criteria for minority applicants may benefit some students at the expense of equally qualified candidates from non-minority backgrounds. Critics argue that this system may inadvertently reinforce stereotypes about minority students having lower qualifications, rather than focusing on enhancing educational opportunities for all. It's essential to question whether these practices fulfill the true goal of fostering diversity while ensuring fair competition. Such discussions may draw on alternative viewpoints from scholars like Richard Kahlenberg, who advocates for class-based affirmative action as a potentially more equitable approach.

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Chapter 17 Summary : 17. Summary of All Tip Factors and Geographic Diversity

17 Summary of All Tip Factors and Geographic Diversity

Tip Factors in Admissions

- Acceptance rates reveal that "tip factors" influence admissions decisions for all applicants, not solely minorities.
- For example, legacies have a 40% acceptance rate, recruited athletes around 60%, and various minority groups have differing rates (e.g., blacks 50%, Hispanics 25%, and Native Americans 30%).
- Despite the preferential treatment indicated by these rates, nonminority applicants do not face a competitive disadvantage.
- Only about 6% of Dartmouth's enrolled students are black, 5% Hispanic, and 1-2% Native American. The majority of admitted students fall into the nontagged applicant category,

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competing solely on academic merit.

Geographic Diversity in Admissions

- Admissions officers do consider geographic diversity; however, acceptance rates across states do not vary significantly.
- The state of application does not influence admission chances. For example, acceptance rates for applicants from Vermont and Maine hovered around the class average, while South Dakota had an acceptance rate of 0% due to unqualified applicants.
- Comparative statistics of applicants from various states show minimal variance from the average acceptance rate of 20%.

Impact of High School Demographics

- The number of applicants from a particular high school does not impact individual admissions. Admissions officers evaluate applicants relative to their class standings.
- The statistics show that high-achieving public schools often have higher acceptance rates than elite private schools, contradicting common perceptions.

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- Public and private school acceptance rates are nearly identical across selective colleges.

Conclusion on Admissions Factors

- Ultimately, factors such as geographic location and high school type play a minimal role in the admissions process. The primary determinant remains the academic strength of the individual applicant, rather than their background or schooling.

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Chapter 18 Summary : 18. The Postgraduate Year

18 The Postgraduate Year

Definition and Purpose

The postgraduate year (PG year) is an additional year of high school, often termed "thirteenth grade," that some students opt to take before attending college. Reasons for choosing a PG year include a lack of academic preparedness, being younger than peers, and a desire to improve poor high school grades in order to qualify for college admissions.

PG Year in Private Schools

Public high schools rarely offer a PG year, leading students to apply to private institutions with established PG programs. Notable examples include Phillips Academy and the Hotchkiss School, where a small percentage of the senior class consist of PG students. These students often do not

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receive financial aid, which benefits the schools financially.

Categories of PG Students

1.

Ivy League-Recruited Athletes

Many PG students at Ivy League schools are recruited athletes who seek to enhance their academic profiles after recognizing that they don't meet admission criteria. These athletes attend private schools to improve their grades while continuing their sport, which aids both their athletic and academic prospects.

2.

Ivy League Applicants (Non-Athletes)

Non-athletes who take a PG year face different challenges. Admissions officers consider both the high school record and

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Chapter 19 Summary : 19.

Postacceptance and Beyond

Section	Summary
Importance of Continued Effort After College Admission	Accepted students should maintain academic performance to honor teachers' support and show a continued love of learning, as disengagement can risk their college admission.
Monitoring of Senior Year Grades by Colleges	Colleges track accepted students' senior year grades, and significant declines may lead to warnings or rescinded admissions, with institutions like Dartmouth conducting systematic reviews.
Consequences of Academic Decline	Students with grade drops receive letters requiring explanations, and subpar performance can lead to being on a watchlist or academic probation, jeopardizing their admission and future.
Benefits of Continuing to Strive Academically	Engagement in academics, especially in AP courses, can provide college credits, save tuition costs, and reinforce dedication while preventing stress when entering college.
Summary	The final year of high school is vital; students should stay diligent in their studies to safeguard future opportunities and rewards.

Postacceptance and Beyond

Importance of Continued Effort After College Admission

Once accepted to a highly selective college, especially under early decision, students may feel tempted to disengage from their studies. However, it is crucial to maintain academic performance to honor the support of teachers and to demonstrate a continued love of learning. A lack of effort can

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lead to disappointment among educators and can even jeopardize the college acceptance.

Monitoring of Senior Year Grades by Colleges

Admissions officers track the performance of accepted students during their senior year. Significant drops in grades can lead to warnings or even rescinded offers of admission. At Dartmouth, for example, a systematic review of student grades is conducted, where declines in academic performance are carefully examined. Appeals for grade drops are a serious matter, and without a legitimate reason for declines, a student risks losing their place at the institution.

Consequences of Academic Decline

Colleges typically send letters to students with significant grade drops, requiring explanations. Subpar performance can put students on a watchlist within the institution, potentially leading to academic probation. Maintaining grades not only safeguards admission but also ensures a positive start to college.

Benefits of Continuing to Strive Academically

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Students are encouraged to stay engaged, especially in AP courses, which can provide college credits and save money on tuition. A continued commitment to academics reinforces dedication and can prevent unnecessary stress or setbacks when entering college.

In summary, the final year of high school is crucial, and students should remain diligent in their studies to protect their future opportunities and rewards.

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Chapter 20 Summary : 20. The Wait List

The Wait List

Understanding the Wait List Process

If you find yourself on a college's wait list, it's essential to understand that each institution has its own policies. Begin by contacting the college to ascertain their specific wait list procedures.

Deciding to Stay on the Wait List

You must first consider whether you want to remain on the wait list. For example, Dartmouth asks candidates to confirm their interest through a card; responding positively places you in a “hot” wait-list category, while no response or a negative reply suggests you’re not interested.

Admissions Decisions from the Wait List

The number of students accepted from the wait list can vary

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significantly, contingent on the school's yield of accepted students. Dartmouth generally admits between fifty to one hundred from its wait list, but there have been years with no admissions from this pool. The wait list serves to retain strong candidates who narrowly missed acceptance due to limited class space.

Who Gets Wait-Listed?

Applicants are typically wait-listed if they receive more acceptance than rejection votes during committee evaluations. Those who are nearly voted in or receive strong support often end up on the wait list. Schools like Princeton use wait lists to show the strength of their applicant pool but tend to admit very few from this group.

Selecting Candidates from the Wait List

If there's room to accept more students, admissions officers prioritize “hot” wait-list candidates based on their evaluations and recommendations from regional officers. At Dartmouth, financial need does not influence wait list decisions, while other colleges may prioritize full-paying applicants.

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Submitting Additional Materials

It's generally not advisable to submit extra materials once wait-listed. Admissions officers prefer to rely on existing applications rather than additional letters of recommendation or insignificant achievements that may clutter their review process.

Communicating Interest

If you're keen on being accepted off the wait list, your guidance counselor can inquire about your standing, especially to communicate your strong interest in the college. However, parents should avoid directly contacting regional officers unless they have significant information.

Conclusion on the Wait List Experience

Most selective colleges resolve their wait list decisions swiftly, typically before early June. If admitted, it's a recognition of your strength as a candidate. The competitive nature of admissions means that many deserving applicants, unfortunately, do not receive offers due to low acceptance rates.

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Chapter 21 Summary : 21.

Communication Among Schools

Chapter 21: Communication Among Schools

Admissions Officers and Conspiracy Theories

The author's misconception in high school suggested that admissions officers at selective colleges, particularly the Ivy League, often communicated and conspired about student admissions. Upon joining the admissions field, the author discovered this idea was unfounded and that actual communication among colleges is minimal.

Ivy League Conferences

Meetings at Ivy League conferences mostly consist of small group discussions on various topics, not collective decision-making. They serve more as networking opportunities, with officers attending a few meetings and engaging in social activities rather than accomplishing

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significant policy changes.

Information Sharing

Some information, such as total applicants, yield rates, and demographic trends, is shared post-admission but there is no real-time communication during application reviews.

Colleges share lists of early decision/admission applicants to ensure compliance with regulations but they do not discuss individual students during the application process.

Concerns About College Communications

The author reassures students not to worry about colleges communicating about their applications. It is critical to follow application rules, especially regarding early decision and action, as violations could lead to rescinded offers.

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Chapter 22 Summary : 22. Financial-Aid Implications and International Students

Financial-Aid Implications and International Students

Overview of Financial Aid and Admissions

Applying for financial aid can influence admission decisions in selective colleges. U.S. citizens and permanent residents may benefit from need-blind admissions policies; however, international students face a more complex landscape due to limited financial aid.

Need-Blind Admissions for U.S. Citizens

Many Ivy League schools are need-blind, meaning financial need does not impact admission decisions. Some schools guarantee full financial support for admitted students, while others may only offer partial aid, requiring students to cover the difference (known as "gapping"). In recent years, there

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have been significant changes in financial aid policies aimed at assisting lower- and middle-income families, with leading institutions eliminating loans in favor of grants and reducing tuition contributions for certain income brackets.

Research on Financial Aid Initiatives

Harvard, Yale, and Dartmouth initiated reforms to broaden financial aid, such as eliminating expected parental contributions based on income thresholds and increasing financial-aid budgets significantly. Other institutions like Duke and Stanford have implemented similar strategies to reduce the financial burden on families.

Impact of Financial Aid Applications

Despite need-blind admissions policies for U.S. citizens, checking the box for financial aid can provide insights into a student's socioeconomic background. Admissions officers may interpret this as an indicator of economic need, potentially affecting their evaluations. As such, students from non-college backgrounds may find that applying for aid enhances their chances of admission, provided they are genuinely seeking assistance.

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Considerations for International Students

International students are defined as non-U.S. citizens without permanent resident status. Unlike domestic applicants, admissions for international students are not need-blind due to limited financial aid budgets, making it crucial for these applicants to consider their financial status when applying. International students who indicate a need for financial aid face stiffer competition, as colleges often prioritize applicants who can pay full tuition.

Admission Process for International Applicants

International applications are usually sorted into need-blind and need-based categories prior to committee evaluation. Those needing aid are reviewed separately, often leading to a lower acceptance rate for this group. The financial aid budget and the applicant's potential contribution play a critical role in admissions outcomes. Limited funding results in high-achieving international students facing tough competition, particularly from countries with limited financial resources.

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Conclusion

Accessibility to top colleges, particularly for international students, is influenced heavily by financial aid needs. U.S. citizens may have better prospects when applying for aid, while international students face greater challenges, which necessitates careful consideration of their financial situations during the application process. Ultimately, understanding these dynamics is crucial for prospective students navigating the admission landscape.

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Chapter 23 Summary : 23. Transfer Students

Transfer Students

Overview of Ivy League Transfer Admissions

Ivy League schools generally accept very few transfer students due to the high number of regular applicants. The acceptance odds for transfers are typically lower than for freshmen. Transfer application deadlines range from March 1 to April 1, with notifications by mid-May. International students applying for transfers with financial aid often have earlier deadlines, such as January 1 for Dartmouth.

Application Review Process

The process for reviewing transfer applications is streamlined and involves fewer admissions officers compared to regular admissions. Each application is reviewed twice and may be forwarded to a transfer committee if needed. Specific

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categories, like athletes and minorities, are factored into the evaluations.

Key Evaluation Criteria

Transfer admissions place significant emphasis on college transcripts and professor recommendations, alongside high school records. The Dartmouth transfer application highlights the importance of college grades, personal essays explaining the transfer motivation, and recommendations. Outside interests and work experience are also considered, along with intangible qualities like creativity and intellectual curiosity.

Diversity Among Transfer Students

Most admitted transfer students do not come from other Ivy institutions; they instead hail from a variety of colleges across the country. Institutions such as Boston University, Ohio State University, and Vassar College were among those that provided transfer students to Dartmouth in 2000.

Conclusion

The transfer admissions process mirrors the regular

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admissions process, meaning the relevant information and strategies discussed earlier are applicable to transfer students as well.

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Chapter 24 Summary : 24. Do You Need an Independent Counselor?

Do You Need an Independent Counselor?

The increasing competition to gain acceptance into highly selective colleges has led to the rise of independent college counselors. While there are qualified professionals in this field, many lack the necessary expertise. Public high school counselors also possess substantial knowledge and resources, making it essential for parents to familiarize themselves with these counselors before seeking independent help.

When to Consider an Independent Counselor

Parents should consider hiring an independent counselor if:

1. The high school counselor appears under-qualified.
2. The high school counselor has an overwhelming caseload.
3. The student has special needs or struggles with writing.
4. The student has exceptional talents requiring specialized guidance.
5. Parents lack the time or knowledge to navigate the process

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effectively.

It's advisable to contact an independent counselor as early as eighth or ninth grade to ensure proper course selection and preparation for college readiness.

Role and Expectations from an Independent Counselor

Independent counselors should focus on understanding the student's interests and matching them with suitable colleges based on their achievements. They are not miracle workers; only the students can secure their admissions. Effective independent counseling should start early, focusing on foundational skills, and should not involve writing essays or directly contacting colleges on the student's behalf.

Maintaining Ethics in Counseling

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Chapter 25 Summary : 25. The Final Rung of the Ladder: Last-Minute Adjustments

25 The Final Rung of the Ladder: Last-Minute Adjustments

Reading Process Limitations

Throughout the application reading process, regional officers are unable to comprehensively compare students within their regions due to the logistics of reading applications over a span of three months. Consequently, different combinations of readers assess applicants from the same high school, introducing variables in evaluation.

Docket Review Process

To address potential inequities, admissions offices allocate time at the end of the reading season for “docket review.” At institutions like Dartmouth, regional officers receive updated

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listings of applicants categorized by high school and state, which facilitates this review. However, due to time constraints, thorough checks may be overlooked during the initial reviews.

Identifying Discrepancies

During docket review, officers may identify cases where students from the same school have disparate admissions outcomes. For instance, if a higher-ranking applicant is rejected while a lower-ranking one is accepted, the officer can investigate further. Commonly, lower-ranking students may have special circumstances, such as athletic recruitment or other flags that justify their acceptance.

Handling Complaints

Complaints from rejected students' families typically arise when a lower-ranking student is accepted, but admissions offices cannot disclose specific details regarding other applicants due to privacy laws. Accepted students might belong to special categories, like athletes or legacies, which complicates public understanding of admissions decisions.

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Final Decision-Making

Even if a regional officer recognizes a potential inequity during the review, the ultimate admissions decision rests with higher authorities within the office. Often, these decisions are influenced by the larger context and criteria that may not be transparent or easily communicated to concerned families. Admissions discussions remain complex, and while officers might understand the nuances, they are not at liberty to fully explain these nuances to the public.

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Chapter 26 Summary : 26. Conclusion

26 Conclusion

Overview of the Admissions Process

The admissions process, while fallible, still yields quality decisions despite varying details across colleges. Based on ten years as a consultant, the author finds that the majority of admissions cases are handled with care, even if some outcomes may seem unjust. Each application receives thorough consideration, and though mistakes happen, the process can be improved.

Flaws in the AI Formula

The current Academic Index (AI) formula, which evaluates applicants, has significant shortcomings. It inadequately compares students from different educational backgrounds, relies heavily on standardized tests, and does not account for factors such as socioeconomic status or intellectual curiosity. The author suggests a more equitable formula focused on

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class rank and reevaluated elements of an applicant's profile.

Suggestions for Improvement

A fairer formula should consider:

- Sole reliance on class rank for schools that provide it.
- Limiting standardized test scores to account for 50% or less of the formula.
- Weighting SAT critical reading/writing more than math.
- Including recommendations from teachers and counselors.
- Factoring in students' writing ability and socioeconomic disadvantages.
- Assessing intellectual curiosity.

Proposed Admissions Process Changes

To enhance the decision-making process, the author advocates for a less formulaic, more human-centered approach. This includes:

- Involving faculty input in evaluations.
- Utilizing diverse experiences among admissions staff.
- Emphasizing qualitative evaluations over quantitative scores.

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Final Thoughts

As applicant pools grow increasingly competitive, colleges must adapt to fairly assess diverse talents and abilities.

Understanding the admissions process is crucial for applicants. The goal of the book has been to demystify this process, making it more accessible, and thereby helping informed applicants increase their chances of acceptance to their desired colleges, regardless of their backgrounds.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Flaws in the Academic Index (AI)

Formula

Critical Interpretation: The author asserts that the AI formula disproportionately favors students from privileged backgrounds while neglecting crucial individual characteristics and societal contexts. This perspective, while compelling, should be scrutinized, as it assumes a binary opposition between objective metrics and subjective qualities without considering that standardized tests may provide some measure of merit and consistency across diverse educational experiences. Critics might argue that completely overhauling the admissions criteria could lead to its own biases or inequalities. For example, research by the National Bureau of Economic Research discusses how various economic factors influence educational opportunities (NBER Working Paper No. 21071). Hence, while Hernández provides sensible recommendations for reform in admissions practices, her critique of the AI formula might oversimplify a complex issue that encompasses merit, privilege, and systemic challenges.

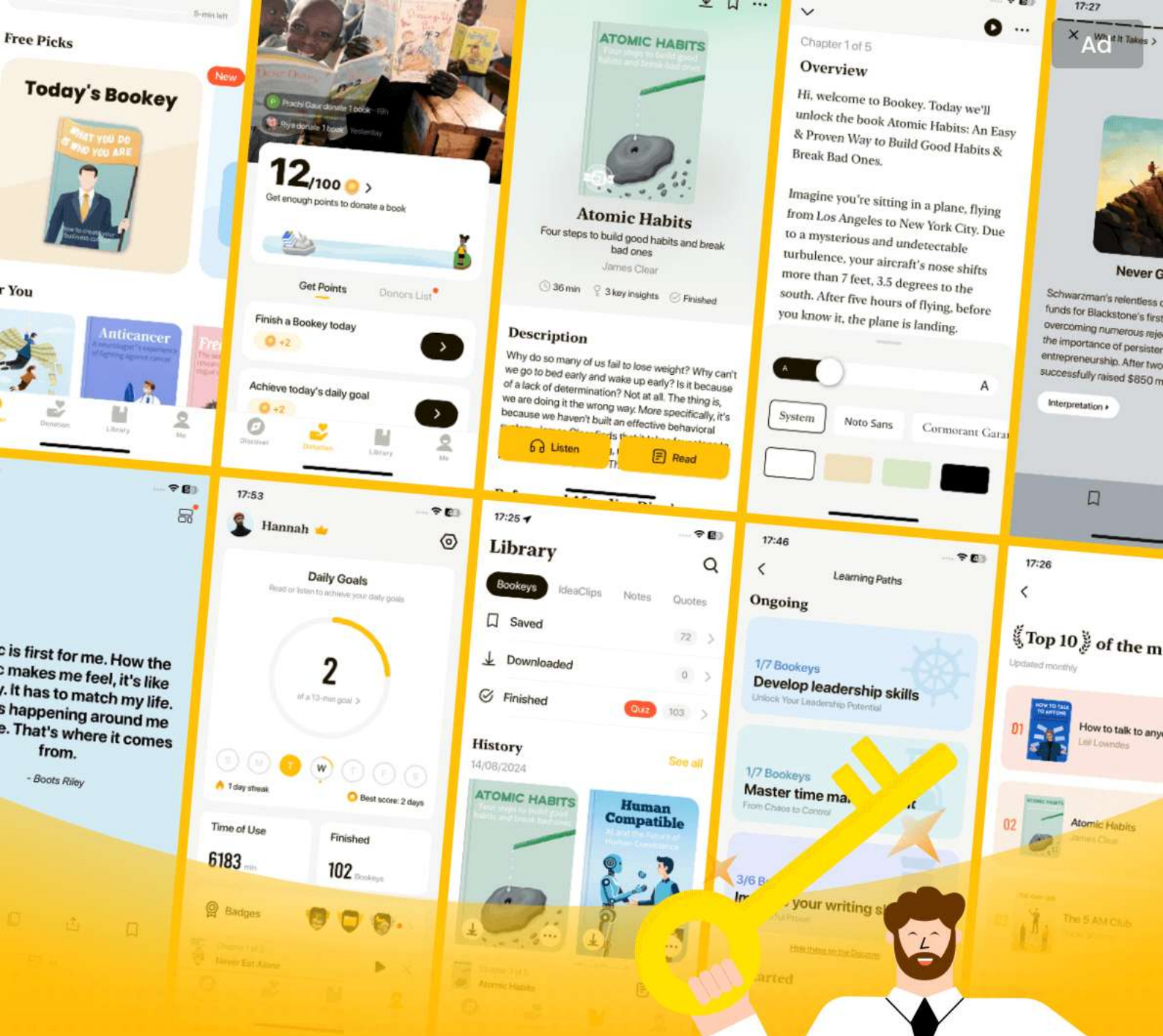
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Chapter 1 | Quotes From Pages 41-59

- 1.The very best of applicants will often be brighter than many of those who will be evaluating them.
- 2.This is your audience. Study them well. Not exactly the Nobel Prize panel.
- 3.Sometimes admissions officers will miss subtle points because they are not extremely perceptive readers, or because they are reading too fast.
- 4.Remember, most recommendations are read quickly and the reader is skimming for main points.
- 5.You have to state where your parents were educated, but when it comes time to put down their jobs, you might want to be somewhat vague.

Chapter 2 | Quotes From Pages 60-97

- 1.The truth is, it's not the level of competitiveness in

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these early years that makes children smarter later on, but, rather, the intellectual stimulation and reinforcement they get at home from their parents and siblings.

2. A love of learning and reading is almost always instilled in students in the home, not in the school.

3. Even if they were not challenged in school, these children could read in their spare time and thus learn many of the skills necessary to succeed in college.

4. What will they add to our college? What kind of impact will they have?

5. The worst thing that teachers could say on your college application is that you are constantly pestering them for a higher grade.

6. You don't even have to go to college, much less an Ivy League school, to be successful.

7. The beauty of an Ivy League/highly selective education lies in the intellectual atmosphere and the collegial bonds formed among students interested in similar ideas and

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fields.

Chapter 3 | Quotes From Pages 98-119

- 1.If you can honestly say to yourself that you prefer one college over all others, applying early decision is a fantastic idea.
- 2.The acceptance rate is invariably higher for early-decision candidates at most of the Ivies, but you have to be sure that the college is truly your first choice.
- 3.Sometimes an officer will remember you or have been impressed after making a personal contact with you, so calling and following up in writing will serve to keep your name in the forefront of his mind.
- 4.The only time an Ivy League school will honor an appeal is if the other awarding college has similar methodology—in those cases, they will usually try to match the scholarship offer.
- 5.In short, applying early decision has many advantages, but it is only for those who are certain in November of their top-choice college.

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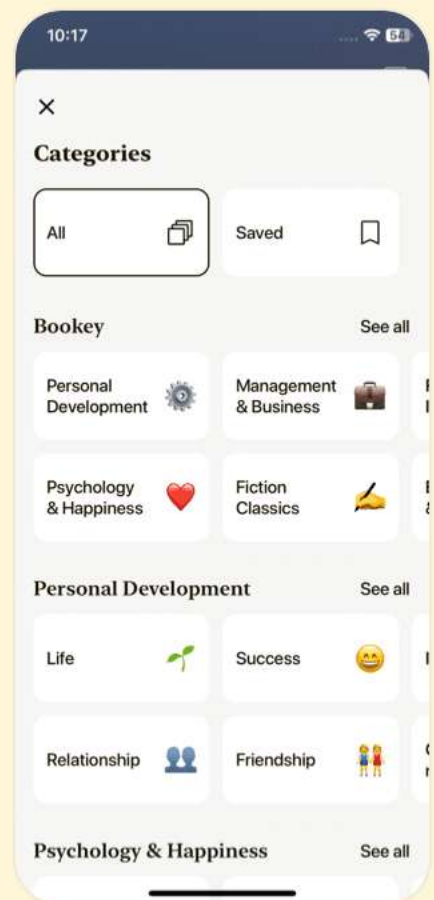
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Chapter 4 | Quotes From Pages 120-148

1. When the College Board decided to set the median once again at a true 500 for both verbal and math, it restored the true bell curve, which peaked at 500 and gently sloped down in both directions toward 800 and 200.
2. In any case, because of all the inequities in scoring, the College Board decided in 1995 to set the median once again at a true 500 for both verbal and math.
3. What used to be considered an unusually high score on the SAT is now just an average score.
4. It is still, as it has always been, more impressive to see high verbal (critical reading) scores than high math scores, since most students at highly selective colleges will be doing much more writing and reading than math.
5. If you want to stand out in the Ivy applicant pool, on the new SAT you should aim for a score of 740 and over on each section, or at least a critical reading score over 730 or so.



6. There has been tremendous confusion over the new scores, which was exacerbated by the fact that the College Board...also changed the duration of the test...and certain sections of the test.

Chapter 5 | Quotes From Pages 149-162

1. For admissions purposes, the most important academic component of your application is your four-year high school transcript, since that represents four years of effort.
2. The real function of these Subject Tests is either to back up all the evidence present in the file or to contradict this evidence.
3. It is fair to say that these Subject Tests are the true equalizers in the admissions process.
4. Despite what Ivy League admissions officers will admit if you ask them, most value high scores and decent grades much more than decent scores and high grades.
5. To attract the best students, it helps tremendously to have impressive standardized-testing averages.

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Chapter 6 | Quotes From Pages 163-215

1. Knowing your academic index, along with having a complete understanding of how applicants are evaluated, will give you a good idea of what your chances are for gaining admission to an Ivy League or highly selective college.
2. The difference between an exact rank and a decile rank, or between a straight GPA and an exact rank, can result in a CRS difference (hence, an AI difference) of as many as twelve to fourteen points.
3. Even if the Ivies were to abolish the AI formula someday, they will still use basically the same process for determining academic merit.
4. Admissions officers are always on the lookout for unfair use of the CRS.
5. To be an academic 1, the student needs many test scores over 700, probably a 4.0 GPA, and at least twenty solid academic classes.





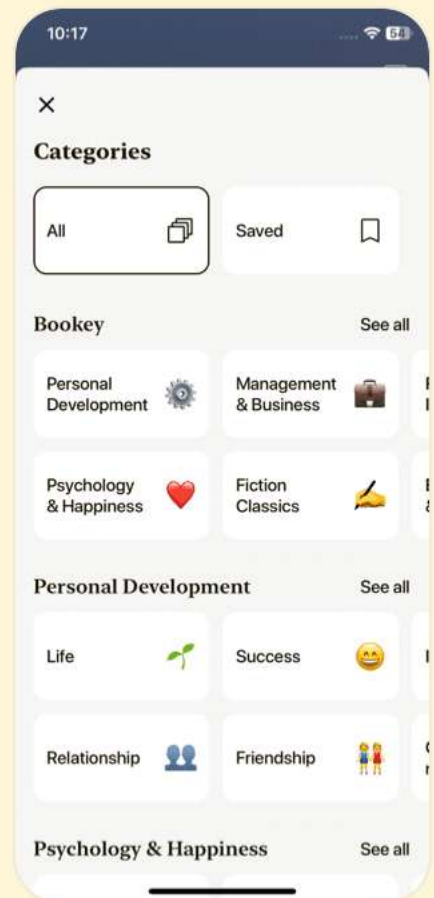
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Chapter 7 | Quotes From Pages 216-228

1. Perhaps the easiest and most effective way to override a mediocre AI and to stand out academically is to score well on Advanced Placement or International Baccalaureate tests.
2. These AP and IB tests are the only tests that are considered to be truly college-level.
3. A big one. Let's say I'm reading a student in the 5 or 6 range who has mid-600 SAT Subject Test scores... then I turn to the student's AP scores and I see that he has a 5 on the AP biology exam, a 5 on the BC calculus exam, and a 4 on the Spanish literature exam.
4. It is even more impressive to have a few strong AP scores, because it means that the student took these exams as a sophomore or a junior, not a senior.
5. The College Board offers several Scholar Awards to recognize high school students who have demonstrated college-level achievement through AP courses and exams.

Chapter 8 | Quotes From Pages 229-250

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- 1.The truth is, admissions offices cannot even tell if you mailed in your material late, as long as you were within one or two weeks of the deadline.
- 2.In other words, it usually works against the students, not for them.
- 3.What is the purpose of sending out these letters? The Ivies and other selective schools feel that they might be able to gain an edge with an exceptional student if they are able to tell him ahead of time that he will be admitted.
- 4.The process is really quite democratic. All the voting is done by majority rule.
- 5.Even in committee, the most interesting students stand out and are chosen over those who are less exciting.

Chapter 9 | Quotes From Pages 251-337

- 1.The easiest way to figure out which schools accept what information is to point your browser to www.commonapp.org and see the helpful chart on the Web site; you can also download supplemental essays for every college.

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- 2.If you feel that you have more to say that was not asked for, simply take the time to write an additional note or essay and submit it.
- 3.Colleges tend to read anything you submit, at least within reason.
- 4.In short, because of all the different possibilities, I just don't see how the common application has simplified the admissions process at all.
- 5.If you don't enjoy intellectual experiences and you don't get a rush from spending time with other high-driving kids, then you might think twice about why you are applying to these top colleges.
- 6.Follow your interests.
- 7.One would hope that students would continue to serve the community for personal and moral reasons, rather than helping others only as a technique for getting into college.
- 8.If you want to read an excellent book on the subject that is short, hilarious, and informative, dig out a copy of Harry Bauld's On Writing the College Application Essay.

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9.If you could take a year off between high school and college, what would you do?

10.Make sure you don't leave any important information out, because if you do, officers are unlikely to find out about it if no one else brings it up.

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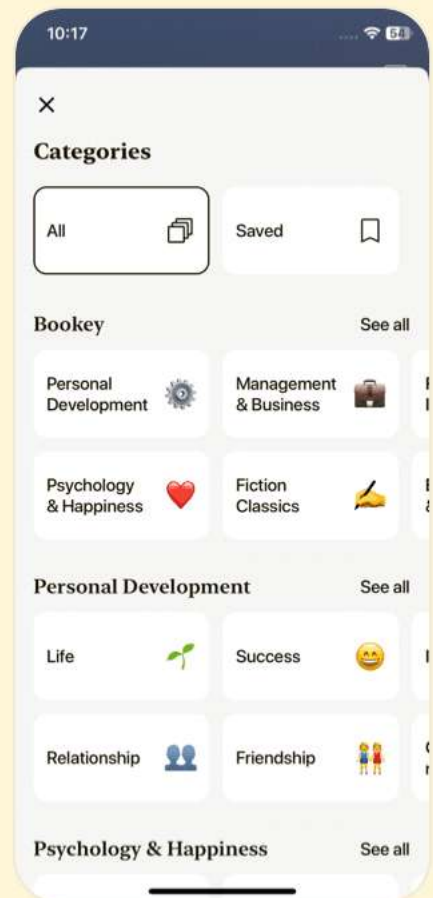
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Chapter 10 | Quotes From Pages 338-356

- 1....the surprising fact is that committees will rarely read beyond the master card, which contains a summary of all the basics, and the ready sheet, which contains the comments of all the individual readers...
- 2....the committee process tends to be fair, if strict (in that the committee has to eliminate five out of every six applicants)...
- 3....he just seems like a cool kid, the kind I'd like to room with.
- 4.The problem is, she didn't stand out from the pack, especially in terms of intellectual power.
- 5....the readers could not tell if she was nearer to the top or to the bottom of the top 10 percent...
- 6.Ultimately, the committee's decisions are about choosing the most interesting students, not just the most accomplished on paper.

Chapter 11 | Quotes From Pages 357-377

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1. These hours can take their toll on academics.
2. If a college wants to take an athlete who is below the minimum AI, it must present that candidate's file to an all-Ivy meeting and provide an explanation that must be approved by the Ivy League deans of admissions.
3. Not all the Ivies are as discriminating as Dartmouth is with its athletic recruits.
4. Coaches make contact with students and try to get a sense of whether their AI would put them within the reach of an Ivy League school.
5. Many times, low AI athletes are accepted because they come from modest backgrounds.
6. The truth is, only a few sports have 'deadweight' athletes, meaning that they only deserve admission based on their athletic skills.
7. What coaches do know is where they have placed you on their recruiting list, so they can make a rough guess as to whether or not you will be admitted.
8. The best thing for prospective recruited athletes to do is to

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take the most demanding course load possible so colleges know that they are looking at a serious student.

Chapter 12 | Quotes From Pages 378-383

1. At most of the highly selective colleges, it is defined as the son or daughter of a graduate from that undergraduate institution.
2. Basically, at all the Ivies, legacies are accepted at twice the rate that everyone else is.
3. Accepting legacies is one of the most effective ways to accomplish this task [building loyalty to the institution].
4. As a result, even at schools like Harvard, legacies are accepted at a much higher rate than the overall pool: in 2005 Harvard accepted 40 percent of legacies compared to 11 percent overall.

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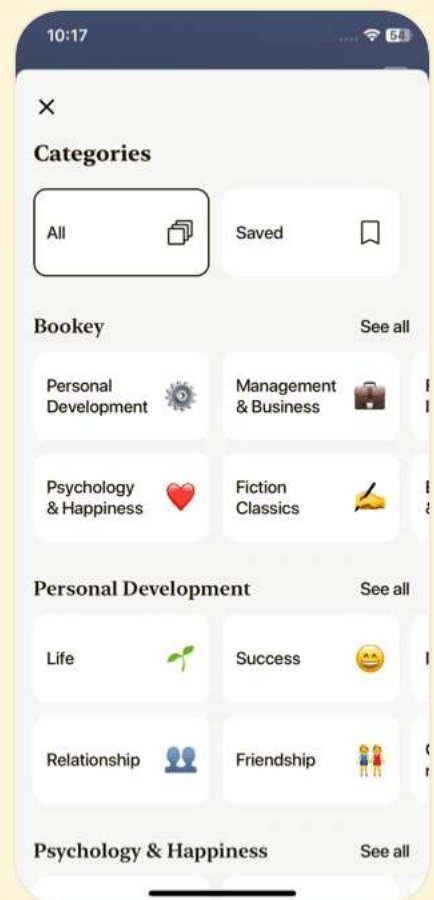
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Chapter 13 | Quotes From Pages 384-388

- 1.If you are a serious cellist, submit a tape only if you want to continue playing in college.
- 2.If a professor writes, 'This is the best oboe player I have heard in the last ten years and I could really use her for the symphony,' you might get a big push.
- 3.If you are strictly an amateur, just list your activity without sending supplementary materials.
- 4.As a general rule, colleges will accept your word in good faith, even if you do not send supplementary materials.

Chapter 14 | Quotes From Pages 389-394

- 1.In plain English, development means 'I will give vast fortunes of money to your college if my child gets accepted.'
- 2.the director of admissions still has total autonomy over the admitted class, so the decision depends upon who the director is.
- 3.The vast majority of students do not fall into this category, so it's not very productive to devote much space to it.



4.It reads like a tawdry novel about the rich and influential and discusses exactly who gets their kids into schools like Harvard based on a monetary figure.

5.the VIP label (as opposed to strictly development) is reserved for celebrity applicants, such as the son or daughter of the president or vice president of the United States or Arnold Schwarzenegger's offspring.

Chapter 15 | Quotes From Pages 395-398

1.A letter from the President of the United States that says that he met you or your parents or knows you does not reveal anything about you that was not already known.

2.It is always better to trust your own academic achievements and let those speak for themselves.

3.Name-dropping in most cases works against you, and the last thing you need when applying to highly selective colleges is a strike against you.

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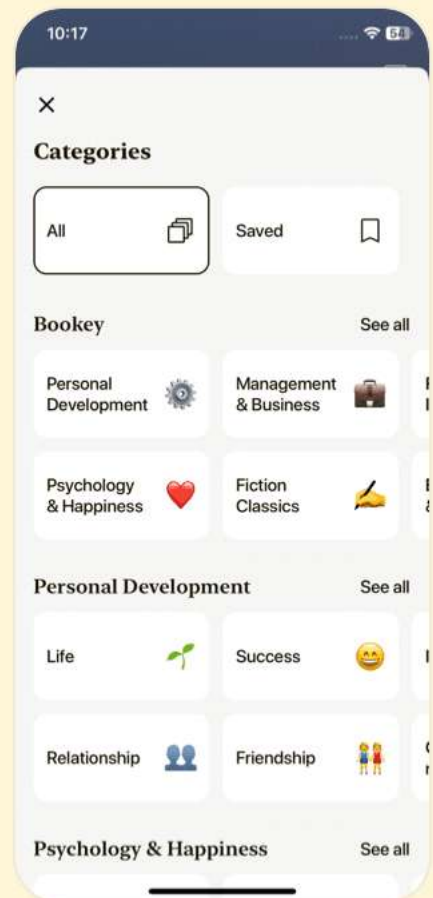
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Chapter 16 | Quotes From Pages 399-422

- 1.The term minority can be misleading.
- 2.It is imperative to distinguish the rhetoric of admissions literature on minority admissions and diversity from the practical implications for your chances of admission.
- 3.Sometimes, the categories are not so clear-cut, and that the idea of an underrepresented minority does not account for the shades of socioeconomic status.
- 4.Colleges simply carved out new exceptions to it based on race and ethnicity.
- 5.It's time to stop the double standard right away.
- 6.These students manage to do fairly well at Dartmouth and their respective colleges, even if they do not graduate at the top of their class.

Chapter 17 | Quotes From Pages 423-436

- 1.If you want to become one of the 60 percent of each year's freshman class that gets in entirely on their academic merit, focus on the factors that are under your control.

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2. The statistics show that where you apply from is not a significant consideration in the admissions process. A top-notch student will stand out whether he is from New York City or North Dakota.
3. The admission rate at these very competitive high schools is higher, not lower, than the average in every case.
4. Again, the same argument applies. The senior class at Hotchkiss already faced a rigorous selection process to get into Hotchkiss in the first place.
5. Thus, of all the tip factors, the ones that play the smallest—indeed, the most insignificant role—are geographic diversity and public versus private high school.

Chapter 18 | Quotes From Pages 437-444

1. ‘In short, it is an extra year of high school (thirteenth grade) before college.’
2. ‘...a late-blooming student might realize that with his very mediocre grades in high school he is not going to qualify for admission to competitive colleges, so he might decide to spend a year at a top prep school to show that he can



handle the challenge of college.'

3. 'The private school benefits by having a star athlete on its team and by having a student who has a good chance of getting accepted at a highly selective college as a recruit.'
4. 'Don't forget that admissions officers at all highly selective colleges, Ivy or non-Ivy, see your four-year high school record and your PG year.'
5. 'What the PG year does not do is salvage a disastrous four-year high school record so that colleges will want to look only at one year and omit the previous four.'

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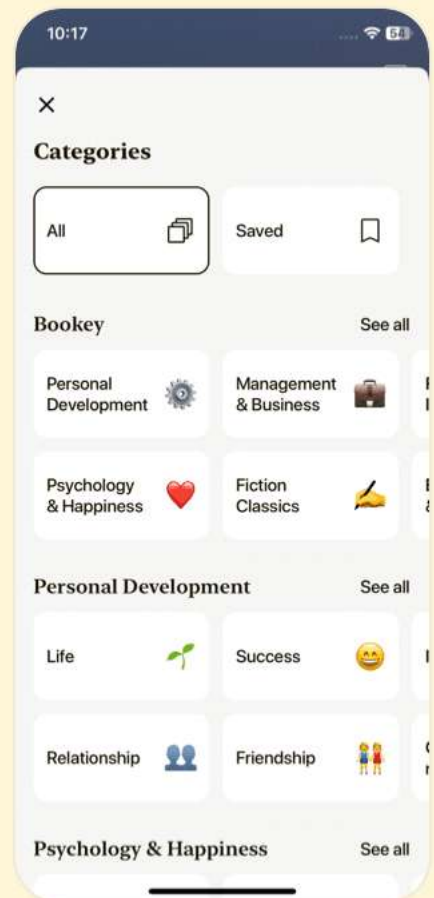
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Chapter 19 | Quotes From Pages 445-451

1. To me, the most important one is that you let down the very teachers who were your staunch supporters.
2. How does going on sabbatical your senior year reflect this love of learning? It doesn't.
3. Even if the admissions office accepts your explanation, you start out your freshman fall under the surveillance of the first-year office.
4. It is easiest to avoid senior slump by staying engaged even after you are admitted to college.
5. After four long years of hard work, it does not pay to slack off during the homestretch.

Chapter 20 | Quotes From Pages 452-461

1. Every college uses its wait list in a slightly different way, so you should call the particular college that wait-listed you and find out its policies.
2. How many do colleges accept from their wait list? That

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really depends on their yield in the first round of accepted students.

- 3.If you have your heart set on getting off the wait list, the most I would suggest is asking your guidance counselor to call in order to see if he can get an accurate indication of where you stand.
- 4.Once again, I would have to say that the very top applicants stand out, even in this wait-list process.
- 5.This is useful information to the regional officer, who could then select that student from his region if he felt so compelled.
- 6.It is rare to drag the wait-list period on past June fifteenth or so.

Chapter 21 | Quotes From Pages 462-471

- 1.There is such a high turnover of Ivy League admissions officers that you could not keep track of all the new people from year to year.
- 2.My overall impression from attending three conferences over a few years was that we didn't really accomplish very

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much except to meet a few of our colleagues and have a mini vacation.

3. The only information that is shared among all highly selective colleges is a list of those students accepted early decision or early action.
4. What would happen if that student who applied to Williams and Yale (and said that Yale was his first choice) got denied by Yale but accepted to Williams?
5. Their main goal is to complete a tremendous amount of reading and evaluation in a relatively short period of time.

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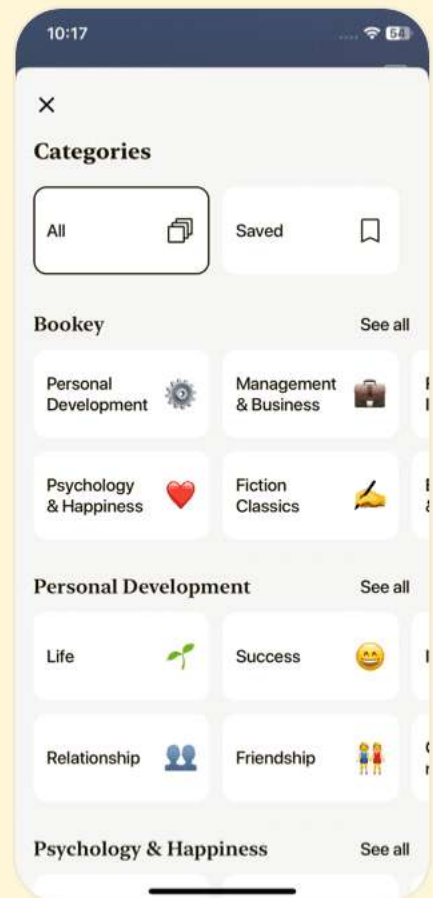
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Chapter 22 | Quotes From Pages 472-490

1. Not all the highly selective colleges are totally need-blind, so before applying, you need to check every college's policy, at least insofar as it concerns your chance for admission.
2. The mere fact that a student checks 'yes' with reference to financial aid does not in fact mean that he will qualify for financial aid or that he will even apply for it.
3. What some colleges do is admit students on a need-blind basis but then resort to 'gapping.'
4. With the many new financial aid initiatives led by Harvard, Yale, Dartmouth, and other Ivies, sometimes applying for financial aid actually helps your odds of admission, especially if you came from a non-college background.
5. Being able to afford the full tuition will give you absolutely no advantage in the admissions process.
6. The sad part is that with all these incredible students to choose from, Dartmouth accepted one or at the most two a year out of the entire group, since they needed a full aid



package.

Chapter 23 | Quotes From Pages 491-495

1. The primary emphasis is placed upon the student's college grades, the essay they submit as to why they want to transfer to Dartmouth, and the various recommendations from their professors and advisors.
2. Personal traits such as creativity and intellectual curiosity are still very much sought by the admissions staff when it comes to transfers.
3. Most of the transfer admits do not come from other Ivy League schools.

Chapter 24 | Quotes From Pages 496-507

1. Only the student himself can get into college.
There are no tricks, no shortcuts that will get a student admitted.
2. The best counselors are those who are able to match the student to the most appropriate colleges, and to guide them along in the process...

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3. A good counselor will know from experience what kind of college the student is capable of getting into and will include a few 'reach' colleges...
4. Remember, a counselor cannot create talent or intelligence—this must come from the student.
5. If anything, these colleges bend over backward to attract talented students from modest backgrounds who do not have the money to hire an independent counselor in the first place.

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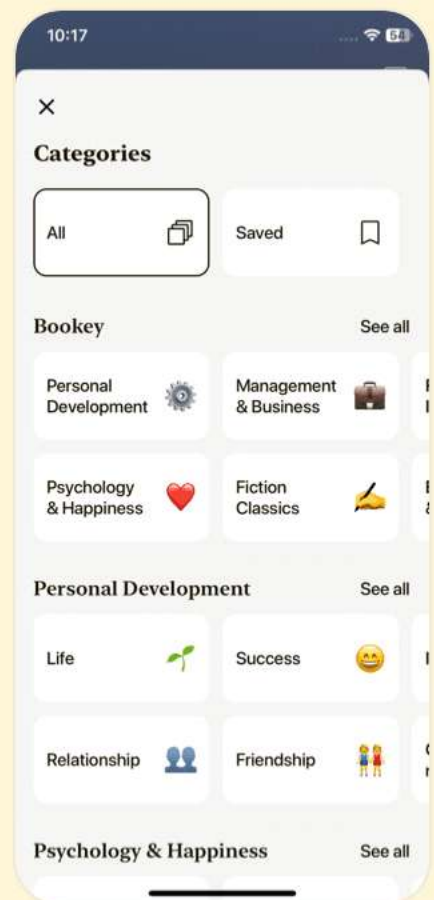
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Chapter 25 | Quotes From Pages 508-513

1. Even if the regional officer decides that there is a major problem in one particular high school and that one applicant who was rejected should have been admitted, the officer would still have to present that case to the director, who would have the ultimate decision-making power.
2. If we could be honest, it would be tempting to give the real reasons, as dispiriting as they might be: 'Yes, your child was number one, but his test scores were more than a hundred points lower than our averages...
3. It is commonplace to accept a lower-ranking athletic recruit at a high school and then turn down a much stronger student from the same high school who unfortunately was not a standout in the overall applicant pool.
4. It is impossible to explain the nuances of all decisions to the public, especially to an angry parent who can't get over the fact that their number-one-ranked child was rejected, while another, lower-ranked student was accepted.



Chapter 26 | Quotes From Pages 514-523

1. At all the highly selective colleges I have listed, officers take their responsibility very seriously and read every folder, no matter how weak it may look at the outset.
2. Sure, there were always students for whom I was an advocate who were not ultimately accepted, but that's part of the democratic decision-making process.
3. The biggest changes in the last ten years haven't been to admissions methodology at all, but rather to the quality and quantity of the applicant pool, which has gone up every year since my book was first published.
4. The more the evaluation takes the form of written comments from admissions officers and faculty, the more it will be able to take into account the more unquantifiable information, such as family background, passion for learning, potential to have a big impact at the college, and strength of intellect.
5. In the meantime, it is my fervent belief that the more you

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know about the admissions process, the better you will be able to do a thorough job of presenting yourself as a person with a vested interest in academics.

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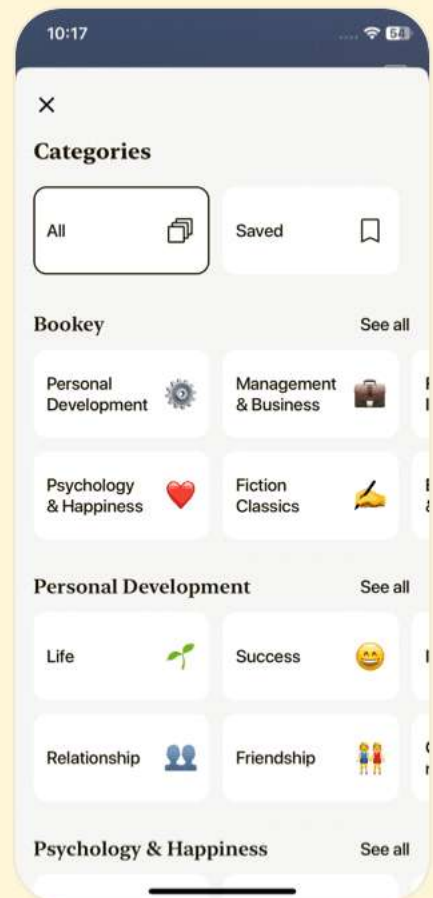
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Chapter 1 | 1. The Target Audience| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of understanding the target audience in college admissions?

Answer:Understanding the target

audience—namely, the admissions officers—enables applicants to communicate more effectively. Since many admissions officers may not come from Ivy League backgrounds and might hold biases against privilege, knowing their perspectives helps applicants present themselves authentically while emphasizing their merits. Adjusting the narrative to highlight strengths without leaning on family background can make a difference in how the application is perceived.

2.Question

How do admissions officers' backgrounds affect their

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evaluations of applicants?

Answer: Admissions officers from less prestigious colleges may unconsciously harbor biases against applicants from wealthy backgrounds. This can lead to a misinterpretation of qualities such as 'quietness' as a lack of potential instead of recognizing it as a thoughtful characteristic. They may overlook significant achievements hidden behind modest presentations.

3.Question

What strategies should students use to present their accomplishments in college applications?

Answer: Students should be direct and clear about their achievements. Instead of implying modesty, they should explicitly state their roles and accomplishments. For instance, stating 'I am the captain of my team' or 'I led a significant community project' emphasizes impact rather than downplaying it.

4.Question

Why is humility important in presenting oneself on

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college applications?

Answer: Humility helps in ensuring that applicants do not alienate admissions officers. By refraining from overtly flaunting their privileged backgrounds and instead presenting a more humble self-portrait, students can avoid preconceived notions of entitlement and foster a more favorable impression.

5.Question

What common misconceptions do applicants have about how family background influences admissions decisions?

Answer: Many students mistakenly believe that their prestigious family background will enhance their application. However, admissions officers may see such backgrounds as setting unrealistic expectations and may judge the applicants more critically based on their achievements relative to their privileges.

6.Question

What can be inferred about the biases of admissions officers towards applicants from privileged backgrounds?

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Answer: Admissions officers may unconsciously hold biases against privileged applicants, expecting more from them due to their advantages. As a result, they might scrutinize their applications more intensively, perceived flaws being magnified in relation to the opportunities they had.

7.Question

How can applicants avoid being misinterpreted due to their perceived background?

Answer: Applicants can focus on providing clear, concise information about their skills and achievements without excessive detail about their family background. This supporting context can bolster their case without drawing undue attention to familial privilege.

8.Question

What does the author suggest about the portrayal of socioeconomic status in applications?

Answer: The author suggests that students should be careful to avoid signaling privilege in their applications. Instead of detailing high-status occupations of parents, they can simply

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state their roles to prevent setting higher expectations that may lead to negative judgments. By being modest about their background, applicants can ensure a fair evaluation based solely on their abilities.

9.Question

What does the author recommend regarding the specificity of parental occupations in applications?

Answer:The author recommends being vague about specific parental occupations, suggesting that applicants use general titles instead of detailed descriptions that imply wealth and privilege. This can help avoid potential biases and allows the admissions committee to focus more on the applicant's merits rather than assumptions based on background.

10.Question

How should applicants and recommenders approach letters of recommendation to avoid being overlooked?

Answer:Applicants and recommenders should avoid subtlety and instead focus on clear, impactful statements that highlight the student's achievements and contributions.

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Direct language, such as 'Student X is the best thinker in our class,' communicates strength effectively, reducing the risk of misinterpretation.

Chapter 2 | 2. The Timetable Through High School: Is Kindergarten Too Early?| Q&A

1.Question

What is the impact of early educational choices on a child's future academic success?

Answer:Parents often believe that if their child does not enter a prestigious preschool or kindergarten, they will be at a disadvantage for college admissions. However, research shows that intellectual stimulation at home and a love for reading are more crucial than the prestige of the school attended early on. A child's intrinsic motivation to learn, fostered primarily at home, can lead to significant academic success later, regardless of the school's reputation.

2.Question

How can parents best prepare their children for high school and college admissions?

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Answer: Parents should focus on fostering a love of learning and reading, supporting their children's interests in educational activities, and encouraging them to take challenging courses. Creating a stimulating home environment where academic pursuits are valued will help students excel in their studies and make a positive impression on future teachers and admissions officers.

3.Question

What should students focus on during their high school years to enhance their college applications?

Answer: Students should prioritize taking honors or advanced level classes and maintain strong grades while actively participating in discussions. They should also pursue extracurricular activities that showcase long-term commitment and leadership. Demonstrating a genuine interest in learning—rather than just grades—can distinguish them from their peers in college admissions.

4.Question

What is the relationship between participation in class and college admissions?

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Answer:Active class participation is crucial for creating a positive impression on teachers, which can influence college recommendations. Students who engage in discussions and show enthusiasm for the material are viewed more favorably than those who are quiet, even if they achieve higher grades.

5.Question

Why is it important to avoid being overly focused on grades during high school?

Answer:Focusing solely on grades can signal to teachers an unhealthy motivation geared towards merely achieving high scores, rather than a genuine interest in learning. Admissions officers are looking for applicants who demonstrate curiosity and passion for their subjects, rather than just a drive to 'get ahead'.

6.Question

What are some effective study strategies for taking standardized tests like SAT or ACT?

Answer:Students should become familiar with the test format and practice regularly to build confidence. Preparation can

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include taking practice tests, reviewing specific content areas, and even participating in prep courses if self-study isn't effective. Quality of preparation is more important than quantity; focused study can improve scores significantly.

7.Question

How do extracurricular activities influence college applications?

Answer:Colleges value long-term commitments to extracurricular activities, as they indicate responsibility, leadership, and the ability to balance competing priorities. Students should seek to engage in meaningful activities that reflect their interests and passions over their high school years.

8.Question

What should students do during their freshman year of high school to set themselves up for success?

Answer:Freshmen should enroll in advanced classes, actively participate in class discussions, and pursue extracurriculars that genuinely interest them. Establishing good study habits

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early is crucial for building a strong foundation for the rest of their high school career.

9.Question

How do SAT Subject Tests factor into college admissions?

Answer:Many selective colleges require or recommend SAT Subject Tests as a way to demonstrate proficiency in specific areas. Students are advised to take these tests shortly after completing the relevant course to capitalize on their recent knowledge.

10.Question

What advice is given to students who are shy or hesitant to speak up in class?

Answer:Shy students are encouraged to take classes or join activities, such as speech or debate, to build their confidence in public speaking. Preparation for class and making small contributions can help them gradually overcome their hesitance and enhance their classroom presence.

11.Question

What is the importance of reading for academic success?

Answer:Regular reading bolsters vocabulary and

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comprehension skills, which are essential for excelling on the SAT critical reading section. The more diverse the reading material, the better prepared students will be to tackle not only standardized tests but also college coursework.

Chapter 3 | 3. Early-Decision and Early-Action Policies| Q&A

1.Question

What is the benefit of applying early decision to Ivy League schools?

Answer:Applying early decision can significantly increase your chances of acceptance at Ivy League schools. For instance, schools like Dartmouth and Columbia show acceptance rates for early decision that are about two to three times higher than regular admission rates. Plus, early decision applicants are often deeply committed to attending, which assures the colleges of a stable incoming class.

2.Question

How should students approach the early decision process?

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Answer: Students should first ensure that they have a clear first-choice college before applying early decision. It's essential to visit campuses, engage in interviews, and reflect on their true preference among schools in the spring or summer before their senior year. If a student has doubts about their choice, it's better to apply during the regular decision cycle.

3.Question

What are potential downsides to applying early decision?

Answer: If students are unsure about their first-choice school or are torn between multiple colleges, applying early decision can lead to regret, especially if they receive acceptance but later wish to attend another institution. Additionally, early decision pools tend to be less diverse and may not fully represent the ideal applicant spectrum.

4.Question

What happens if a student is deferred after applying early decision?

Answer: Being deferred means a student's application will be

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reconsidered in the regular admission cycle. It's important for students to follow up with the admissions office, gauge their standing, and provide updates on any academic improvements or achievements while maintaining a positive, professional demeanor.

5.Question

Do early decision applicants receive different financial aid packages compared to regular decision applicants?

Answer:No, early decision applicants receive financial aid packages similar to regular decision applicants. Ivy League schools are need-blind and apply the same financial aid criteria across the board, with no advantage given to when the application is submitted.

6.Question

What should low-income students consider when thinking about applying early decision?

Answer:Low-income students should feel empowered to apply early decision at Ivy League schools, as many of these institutions offer generous financial aid packages that cover

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full need without loans. This can allow them to attend their top-choice schools without financial concern.

7.Question

What actions can students take to increase their chances of admission after being deferred?

Answer:Students can reaffirm their interest in the college by writing a brief letter, updating their file with new grades or accomplishments, and potentially including one new letter of recommendation. They should approach this process thoughtfully and respectfully, avoiding excessive communication.

8.Question

What is the 'Harvard/Princeton effect'?

Answer:The 'Harvard/Princeton effect' reflects how the abolishment of early decision policies at these institutions led other students to shy away from binding early decision applications, favoring non-binding early action options at other colleges instead.

9.Question

What does a high yield of early decision applicants

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indicate for Ivy League schools?

Answer:A high yield of early decision applicants means colleges can predict and stabilize the composition of their incoming class, as these students are bound to attend if accepted. This predictability is advantageous for maintaining enrollment and building a loyal alumni base.

10.Question

How can understanding the early decision process help students navigate college admissions?

Answer:By comprehending the nuances of early decision policies, acceptance rates, and the importance of demonstrating genuine interest, students can make more informed and strategic choices that align with their academic goals and personal preferences.

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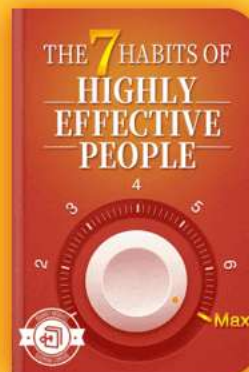
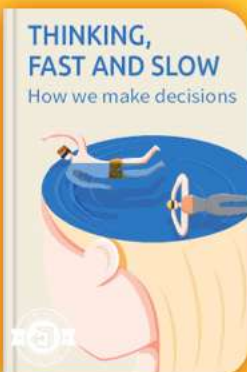


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Chapter 4 | 4. The New SAT and the ACT and Recentering| Q&A

1.Question

What are the significant changes in the SAT as discussed in this chapter?

Answer:The SAT underwent dramatic changes, particularly with the recentering process, which set the median score again at 500 for both verbal and math. This adjustment was crucial because scores could no longer be directly compared to older scores. The distribution of scores changed, creating a more accurate reflection of student performance as the test was normalized to account for the increased diversity among test-takers.

2.Question

How did score recentering affect the perception of SAT scores?

Answer:Before recentering, a combined score of 1,400 was considered very high. Post-recentering, this score became average for selective colleges. Thus, applicants now need to

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aim much higher to stand out.

3.Question

In what way do SAT and ACT scores compare, according to the chapter?

Answer:The ACT allows students total score choice and does not penalize for guessing, which can lead to potentially higher scores for students compared to the SAT. Additionally, there was an increase in popularity for the ACT due to its format and scoring flexibility.

4.Question

What implications does this have for students preparing for college admissions?

Answer:Students must now be more strategic about their test-taking. They need to focus on achieving higher scores, especially above the recentered medians, and understand the importance of score breakdowns (especially in critical reading) over total scores. Moreover, they should determine which test aligns better with their strengths early in their high school career.

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5.Question

Why is it important for students to familiarize themselves with score conversion tables?

Answer:Score conversion tables are vital for understanding how old SAT scores compare to the new recentered scores. Parents and students must recognize that a score that seems higher may not indicate a stronger performance due to the changes in score distribution.

6.Question

What misunderstandings can arise from comparing scores within the same family?

Answer:Due to recentering, a younger sibling may have appear to have a higher score at first glance, but the comparison is misleading if the older sibling's scores were based on the old system. Specific score conversion tables should be used to ensure a fair comparison.

7.Question

What is the underlying criticism against the SAT and its connection to socioeconomic status?

Answer:The chapter argues that the SAT favors wealthier

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students because they can afford extensive test preparation, thereby inflating their scores. It suggests that the focus should be on eliminating the SAT requirements altogether, as it does not effectively measure a student's academic capabilities.

8.Question

How should students determine how many times to take the SAT?

Answer:It is generally advised that students take the SAT no more than two or three times. After that, scores tend to plateau, and taking it excessively may give the impression of score obsession rather than academic merit.

9.Question

What is the difference in scoring between the various sections of the SAT as highlighted in the chapter?

Answer:The verbal (now critical reading) scores are generally valued more highly in college admissions because they reflect a student's reading and writing skills, which are crucial for academic success, whereas the SAT math section

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covers basic skills that may not correlate with future performance in more advanced math courses.

10.Question

What insight does the chapter provide about the relationship between preparation and score improvement?

Answer:The chapter emphasizes that score improvements on the SAT often reflect how well a student has prepared for the test rather than their innate abilities. This highlights the significant advantage that comes with access to resources for test prep.

11.Question

What recommendations does the author make regarding the use of the SAT and college admissions?

Answer:The author recommends that colleges should reconsider their reliance on SAT scores for admissions, as they do not accurately represent a student's potential. Instead, colleges might benefit from considering alternative assessments that better reflect academic skills.

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Chapter 5 | 5. The Importance of the SAT Subject Tests| Q&A

1.Question

Why do admissions officers place significant weight on SAT Subject Tests over high school transcripts?

Answer:Admissions officers often prioritize SAT Subject Tests because high school transcripts can lack context. Many high schools don't rank students or provide enough detail about GPA, making it hard for colleges to gauge a student's relative performance. Without clear indicators, such as class rank, admissions officers worry that they could be misled about a student's academic standing and, as a result, may rely more heavily on standardized test scores to evaluate academic ability.

2.Question

How do SAT Subject Tests function as equalizers in the admissions process?

Answer:SAT Subject Tests serve as equalizers by providing a standardized assessment of knowledge across different high

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school environments. For instance, they allow admissions officers to compare students from small schools, where competition is lower, with those from larger schools.

Regardless of the students' respective environments, Subject Test scores afford a common basis for assessment, tackling discrepancies in grading scales and teacher evaluations.

3.Question

What implications do poor SAT Subject Test scores have for a student with a high GPA?

Answer: Poor SAT Subject Test scores can undermine the impression created by a high GPA. For example, a straight-A student with low Subject Test scores may be seen as diligent but potentially lacking in insight or ability compared to peers with high test scores that suggest a deeper understanding of the subject matter. Admissions officers might question whether the high GPA reflects a challenging curriculum or if the student is simply good at gathering grades without corresponding academic ability.

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What strategies should students consider if they identify as 'poor testers'?

Answer: If students identify as poor testers, they should focus on thorough preparation for Subject Tests to improve their performance. They need to grasp the material thoroughly enough to complete the tests efficiently under time constraints. It's essential to practice working effectively within strict time limits, as doing well on these tests can validate their academic strengths despite any testing anxiety.

5.Question

How do admissions officers interpret discrepancies between high test scores and low grades?

Answer: High test scores combined with modest grades might lead admissions officers to conclude that a student could be bored or under-challenged in their current academic environment. It suggests potential that may be unlocked in a more stimulating atmosphere, prompting them to favor these students over those who may have better high school performance but weaker standardized test outcomes.

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6.Question

What underlying message can students extract about the testing landscape in college admissions?

Answer:Students should recognize that while high grades are important, standardized tests like the SAT Subject Tests play a crucial role in college admissions, especially at competitive institutions. It's essential to balance academic performance with strong test scores to present a compelling overall application. Thus, students are encouraged to leverage their test strengths and prepare extensively for standardized assessments.

Chapter 6 | 6. The Academic Index (AI)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the Academic Index (AI) and why is it significant in the Ivy League admissions process?

Answer:The Academic Index (AI) is a composite score used by Ivy League admissions offices that evaluates a student's test scores and high school class rank. It is significant because it quantifies a

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student's academic qualifications on a scale of 1 to 240, which aids admissions officers in comparing applicants from different high schools and academic environments. Despite its importance, the AI formula has remained largely undisclosed to the public, making it a 'trade secret' that offers insight into the rigorous admissions standards of elite institutions.

2.Question

How do standardized test scores impact the AI, and what percentage of admissions decision is influenced by academic rankings?

Answer: Standardized test scores, including the SAT and SAT Subject Tests, constitute a significant part of the AI calculation, contributing approximately two-thirds of the total score. Academic rankings, derived from a student's GPA and class standing, generally account for 70 to 85 percent of the final admissions decision. This highlights the emphasis Ivy League schools place on academic performance over

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extracurricular achievements.

3.Question

What inequities can arise from the AI calculation, particularly regarding student rankings from different high school sizes?

Answer: Inequities arise primarily because the AI calculation can disadvantage students from smaller high schools. For instance, the top-ranked student from a class of 24 can only achieve a maximum CRS of 70, while a student from a larger class has the potential for a perfect CRS of 80. This disparity can impact overall competitiveness in admissions, as smaller class sizes tend to mean lower CRS scores even for top students, which may unfairly reduce their chances of acceptance to highly selective colleges.

4.Question

How can understanding the AI help students estimate their chances of admission to Ivy League schools?

Answer: By calculating their own AI based on SAT scores and class rank, students can gain a clearer picture of where they stand relative to admitted students. This understanding

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can help them identify areas for improvement, whether in enhancing test scores, boosting GPA, or demonstrating academic interest outside the classroom, thereby strengthening their overall application.

5.Question

What strategies can students employ to improve their academic rankings and AI scores?

Answer:Students can improve their academic rankings and AI scores by taking advanced courses (like AP or honors classes), consistently performing well in school, showcasing leadership in extracurricular activities, and seeking opportunities for independent study or research.

Additionally, they should aim to secure strong, personalized recommendations from teachers and maintain a genuine passion for learning, which can also reflect positively in their applications.

6.Question

Why is it important for high school counselors to report student performance accurately?

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Answer: Accurate reporting of student performance, whether through exact rankings, weighted GPAs, or clear descriptions of academic rigor, is crucial. This helps admissions officers better understand a student's true academic standing and potential. Inaccurate or vague reporting can lead to a misrepresentation of an applicant's capabilities, which could ultimately result in unfairly low CRS and AI scores, affecting the student's chances of admission to top colleges.

7.Question

What is the relationship between AI scores and acceptance rates by Ivy League schools?

Answer: There is a strong correlation between AI scores and acceptance rates in Ivy League schools. Higher AI scores significantly increase the likelihood of admission, as seen in the admissions statistics from Dartmouth, where academic 9s had a 94% acceptance rate, while academic 5s had only a 25% acceptance rate. This indicates that applicants with better academic profiles are much more likely to gain admission.

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8.Question

What should students do if they find themselves in the lower academic rankings (1, 2, or 3)?

Answer:Students in the lower academic rankings should focus on highlighting their unique strengths, such as overcoming challenges, involvement in community service, or exceptional talents in specific fields. They should obtain compelling recommendations from teachers that include personal insights, demonstrate resilience and improvement in their academic trajectory, and showcase their passion for learning through well-crafted essays.

9.Question

What character traits or qualities could lead to rejection despite high academic scores (7, 8, or 9)?

Answer:Students may face rejection despite high academic scores if they exhibit negative character traits, such as intolerance or lack of personal initiative outside the classroom. Admissions officers look for well-rounded individuals who contribute positively to campus life;

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insufficient extracurricular involvement, poor essays, or disciplinary issues can diminish even strong academic profiles.

10.Question

How does the AI reflect a student's academic passion beyond just scores and rankings?

Answer: While the AI serves as a quantifiable measure of academic performance, admissions officers also look for qualities such as intellectual curiosity and a genuine love for learning, which can be evident in essays, recommendations, and extracurricular involvement. These aspects enrich a student's application and reinforce the notion that educational engagement extends beyond grades and test scores alone.

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Chapter 7 | 7. Advanced Placement Scores| Q&A

1.Question

How important are Advanced Placement (AP) and International Baccalaureate (IB) scores in college admissions?

Answer:AP and IB scores are crucial as they showcase a student's capability to thrive in a college-level academic environment. High scores can significantly enhance a student's application, often overshadowing mediocre scores from standardized tests like the SAT.

2.Question

What distinguishes AP tests from SAT Subject Tests?

Answer:AP tests are more akin to college-level exams, focusing on writing and problem-solving rather than multiple-choice questions. They assess a student's ability to engage critically with content in a way that SAT Subject Tests do not.

3.Question

What benefits accrue from achieving a high AP score?

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Answer: High AP scores can contribute to college credit, enhance a student's application by reflecting competency in challenging subject matter, and can increase a student's academic rating in college admissions, demonstrating preparedness for rigorous coursework.

4.Question

Why should students consider taking AP exams even if they are not enrolled in the class?

Answer: Students can register for AP exams independently of class enrollment, allowing them to showcase their knowledge and competency. This strategy can enhance their college applications, particularly if they achieve high scores.

5.Question

What is the significance of AP Scholar awards?

Answer: AP Scholar awards offer recognition for outstanding academic achievement, which can enhance a college application. These awards indicate a student's capability and ambition, setting them apart in a competitive admissions landscape.

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6.Question

How can AP scores impact an applicant's perceived academic abilities?

Answer:Strong AP scores can elevate a student's profile, especially if they surpass their SAT Subject Test scores.

Admissions officers often regard them as more indicative of a student's preparedness and potential for college success.

7.Question

In what ways can taking AP courses early in high school benefit students?

Answer:Taking AP courses early allows students to accumulate high AP scores prior to their senior year, demonstrating their commitment to challenging coursework. Early scores can positively influence admissions decisions before the typical college application review period.

8.Question

What should students do if they receive a low AP score?

Answer:Students can choose to suppress low AP scores when reporting to colleges, allowing them to present only their best performances. However, they should be mindful that low

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scores may reflect inadequacies in the same subject area on other assessments.

9.Question

What strategies can a student use to improve their AP exam performance?

Answer:Engaging with practice tests, closely following the College Board's curriculum, and taking AP courses seriously can prepare students for successfully tackling AP exams.

10.Question

How can strong AP scores influence the overall academic evaluation of an applicant?

Answer:High AP scores may lead admissions officers to re-evaluate a student's academic standing; for instance, a student with a lower AI might find their rating boosted by exceptional AP results, indicating their high academic potential.

Chapter 8 | 8. The Reading Process| Q&A

1.Question

What is the initial process of assembling an application file at Ivy League schools?

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Answer: The initial process involves receiving various pieces of mail that include the student application, high school information, teacher recommendations, and sometimes peer recommendations. Admissions staff members sort this mail alphabetically and input the data into a computer system over a set period.

2.Question

Why do Ivy League schools accept late applications, sometimes up to March?

Answer: Ivy League schools aim to increase their application numbers to appear more selective, so they may accept late applications as long as they are submitted within a reasonable timeframe around the deadline.

3.Question

What is the role of regional admissions officers during the application process?

Answer: Regional admissions officers visit high schools to gather information, meet students, and assess the academic

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environment. They provide insights to help in evaluating applicants from their assigned regions.

4.Question

How do admissions staff make decisions between applicants during the committee process?

Answer:Decisions are made based on comparisons among applicants' academic and extracurricular achievements, exemplified through ratings and the committee's discussions about each candidate's unique qualities.

5.Question

What is a 'likely letter' and why is it sent to certain applicants?

Answer:A 'likely letter' is a notification sent to exceptional applicants indicating that they are likely to be admitted, aiming to entice them to choose that college over others.

6.Question

How does the admissions office ensure its reading process is fair and consistent?

Answer:The admissions process incorporates checks and balances, including multiple readers for each application,

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regional knowledge, and a director who oversees decisions, allowing for a democratic vote on admissions.

7.Question

What impact do personal interactions between admissions officers and students have on the application process?

Answer:Personal interactions are generally perceived to have little long-term impact, as officers meet many students in short periods and do not retain detailed memories of individual interactions.

8.Question

How do Ivy League colleges address the issue of socioeconomic diversity in their applicant pool?

Answer:Colleges are increasingly targeting recruitment efforts towards less affluent areas to improve access and ensure that students from diverse socioeconomic backgrounds are included in their applicant pool.

9.Question

Why might a high school visit by an admissions officer be considered ineffective?

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Answer: Many students from well-resourced schools are already familiar with colleges, making these visits less impactful, especially when they are used more as a means of appeasing alumni or school counselors.

10. Question

What are the typical statistics regarding acceptance in Ivy League schools during the committee phase?

Answer: Typically, only about one-sixth of applicants reviewed by the committee will be accepted, indicating the highly selective nature of admissions at these institutions.

Chapter 9 | 9. A Step-by-Step Look at How Your Application Is Read and a Brief Look at the Common Application| Q&A

1. Question

What does the author imply about the effects of the Common Application on college admissions?

Answer: The author suggests that while the Common Application was intended to simplify the college admissions process, it has, in reality, complicated it further by leading to numerous supplemental essays

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and requirements that vary by school. Additionally, the author expresses a belief that the Common Application tends to stifle creativity in student responses, resulting in dull applications.

2.Question

Why is the pre-application important, according to the chapter?

Answer:The pre-application is important because it allows colleges to gather basic information about the applicant and helps set up their file. Submitting it early can also demonstrate a student's interest in the school, particularly for early decision applications, and ensures that the application fee is addressed promptly.

3.Question

What advice does the author give regarding the optional ethnicity section of the application?

Answer:The author advises students, especially those from minority backgrounds, to fill out the optional ethnicity section of the application honestly, as it can positively

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influence their application. They also mention that students should give a complete picture of their identity, even if that includes multiple ethnicities.

4.Question

How should students approach filling out the academic interests section of the Common Application?

Answer:Students should research the colleges they are applying to and select less common academic interests when possible. By doing so, they can stand out more in a competitive applicant pool, as colleges often have many applicants expressing interest in popular majors.

5.Question

What is the significance of the activity chart in the application?

Answer:The activity chart is significant because it provides admissions officers with insight into the applicant's depth of commitment and leadership in their extracurricular involvements. It's more impactful to show focused involvement rather than a long list of shallow participation.

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6.Question

What characteristics do colleges typically look for in recommendations from teachers?

Answer:Colleges look for recommendations that highlight the student's academic strengths, involvement in class, and potential to contribute to the academic environment. They prefer concise, honest recommendations that confirm what they've learned from other parts of the application, rather than vague affirmations.

7.Question

What can a student do if they feel their application does not fully represent their strengths?

Answer:Students are encouraged to submit additional notes or essays that elaborate on aspects not covered in the main application, which can provide a fuller picture of their abilities and experiences.

8.Question

What qualities are admissions officers looking for during the personal interview?

Answer:During the personal interview, admissions officers

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are looking for intellectual curiosity, passion for learning, and the ability to articulate one's interests and experiences. They assess how well the applicant fits with the college's community and culture.

9.Question

How important is the personal essay in the college application process?

Answer: The personal essay can be crucial for applicants in the middle range of academic metrics (scores and grades), as it offers them an opportunity to showcase their unique qualities and experiences. However, for very strong or weak applicants, the essay's impact varies—strong applicants may be accepted regardless of essay quality, while weak essays can significantly affect less competitive students.

10.Question

What should students avoid discussing in their applications when trying to present their life experiences?

Answer: Students should avoid discussing privilege or travel experiences that focus solely on leisure rather than personal

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Chapter 10 | 10. A Brief Trip to the Committee| Q&A

1.Question

What is the selection process for applicants in admissions committees and how does it impact their chances of acceptance?

Answer: The selection process involves a meticulous review of folders by admissions officers, where strong ('A') and weak ('R') applications are filtered out. Only those with uncertain ratings ('P' for possible) move forward to the committee. The director uses collective feedback to recommend folders for acceptance or rejection, significantly impacting the chances for borderline applicants. Committees typically accept only one out of every six applicants, making the process quite competitive.

2.Question

How do admissions committees evaluate an applicant's extracurricular activities alongside their academic achievements?

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Answer: Extracurricular activities are critically assessed to gauge a student's commitment and character. For instance, in the case of Josh, although he had strong academic ranking, the committee noted a lack of leadership in his extracurriculars, leading to a rejection. Conversely, Jesse's unique pursuits outside the classroom impressed the committee, showcasing the importance of being well-rounded and genuinely passionate about personal interests.

3.Question

What qualities do admissions committees look for in applicants beyond academics?

Answer: Admissions committees seek students who are intellectually curious, engaged, and able to contribute to campus life. For example, Jesse stood out not just for his academic interests but for his enthusiasm and initiative in projects that benefited his classmates. The ability to demonstrate passion, creativity, and a desire to enrich the academic community is crucial for making a lasting

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impression.

4.Question

How does the diversity of an applicant pool influence the decision-making within admissions committees?

Answer:Diversity is a significant factor, as seen with the African-American applicant case. While the committee is mindful of maintaining diversity, decisions are still based on perceived merit and qualifications. In cases where candidates did not show unique contributions or academic rigor, they were ultimately rejected despite diversity concerns.

5.Question

What role does the recommendation letter play in an applicant's acceptance?

Answer:Recommendation letters provide insight into an applicant's personality and contributions beyond grades. However, if they are lukewarm or generic, as with the Korean-American candidate, they may detract from an applicant's overall impression. Strong, personal endorsements can significantly bolster an application, while

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weak or lacking letters can lead to rejections.

6.Question

Why is it important for applicants to showcase their passion for learning in their applications?

Answer: Demonstrating a true love of learning differentiates students in a competitive field. The admissions committee looks for applicants who are not only academically capable but also inquisitive and innovative. Applicants like Jesse, who actively pursued interests independently, left a positive impression, while more conventional presentations, like the Korean-American girl, failed to capture that interest.

7.Question

How does the admissions committee's structure and dynamics influence the final decision on applications?

Answer: The structure of committees—such as the number of members, their backgrounds, and discussion styles—affects deliberations. Committees with varying methodologies, like rotating readers or tackling folders collectively, yield different insights. This dynamic can lead to richer

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discussions and outcomes that might vary significantly between committees or sessions.

8.Question

What can applicants learn from the rejection of typically strong candidates?

Answer:Even strong candidates can be rejected if they lack distinctiveness or fail to exceed standard expectations. The importance of academic rigor, strong recommendations, and unique contributions to community life are critical for acceptance. This highlights the need for applicants to truly distinguish themselves and not merely meet the minimum criteria.

9.Question

How does financial need impact the admissions process, particularly for international applicants?

Answer:Financial need is a unique consideration that can affect admissions, especially for international applicants. Even in need-blind institutions, international students with significant financial needs may face additional scrutiny or

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different processes, as committees aim to balance financial constraints with the need for a diverse student body.

Chapter 11 | 11. Flags and Tags: Athletic Recruiting at the Ivy League Schools| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of an athlete's Academic Index (AI) in Ivy League admissions?

Answer:The AI is crucial for Ivy League admissions as it helps determine if an athlete qualifies for acceptance. Ivy League schools have a specific AI cutoff, approximately around 169 for athletes. If an athlete's AI is significantly lower than the school's average, their recruitment must be justified at an all-Ivy meeting. This ensures that while admissions consider athletic talent, they also maintain academic standards.

2.Question

How are athletic recruits prioritized in the admissions process?

Answer:Recruited athletes are placed on a coach's list based

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on their athletic ability and academic qualifications. The higher an athlete ranks on this list, the more influence a 'purple tag' (indicating their status as a recruited athlete) will have on their chances of admission. Coaches' evaluations and their ability to match athletes with the school's academic standards are critical.

3.Question

Why might strong academic athletes still find themselves sidelined in favor of lower AI recruits?

Answer:In competitive sports environments, teams often need a mix of skills and academic profiles. A brilliant student with a high AI might not be given playing time because their AI balances out lower-ranked athletes who may be inherently better players. This illustrates a complex balance between academic standards and athletic performance.

4.Question

What challenges do coaches face when recruiting athletes for Ivy League schools?

Answer:Coaches face the challenge of finding top athletic

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talent that also meets the academic standards required for Ivy League admission. This process requires understanding both the athlete's potential on the field and their ability to handle rigorous academic coursework.

5.Question

How does the admissions process differ for recruited athletes compared to regular applicants?

Answer:Recruited athletes, while still undergoing the standard admissions evaluation, gain a different perspective from admissions officers who will look for strengths rather than weaknesses in their applications. This is influenced by the coach's recruitment tags, making their athletic potential a significant factor in acceptance.

6.Question

What is a 'squeeze play' and how does it impact recruited athletes?

Answer:A 'squeeze play' occurs when a college offers an athlete guaranteed admission if they commit to attending, prompting the athlete to inform their Ivy League options of

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this offer. It accelerates the admissions timeline, allowing athletes to receive admission decisions much earlier than the standard timeline.

7.Question

What is the argument for accepting low AI athletes into Ivy League colleges?

Answer:The rationale for accepting low AI athletes is that their dedication to achieving Division I-level skills comes with substantial time investment, which can hinder academic performance. Accepting these athletes recognizes their commitment and talent, providing opportunities for exceptional individuals who have excelled in their sports despite academic challenges.

8.Question

How do Ivy League schools maintain competitive sports teams despite not offering athletic scholarships?

Answer:Ivy League schools rely on the inherent appeal of their academic reputation and the lure of a prestigious education to recruit talented athletes, even without financial

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incentives. Their ability to attract impressive athletes demonstrates that despite restrictions, they can compete at a high level against universities that provide athletic scholarships.

Chapter 12 | 12. Flags and Tags: Legacies| Q&A

1.Question

What is the definition of a legacy in the context of college admissions?

Answer:A legacy is defined as the son or daughter of a graduate from the undergraduate institution to which the student is applying. In most cases, only parents' attendance counts, not grandparents, siblings, or relatives who attended graduate schools.

2.Question

How do legacy admissions impact the acceptance rates at Ivy League schools?

Answer:Legacies generally have acceptance rates that are significantly higher than non-legacies. For example, at Dartmouth, the acceptance rate for legacies is around 40%,

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compared to an overall rate of 15-20%. This means legacies are often given an advantage in the admissions process.

3.Question

What economic rationale do Ivy League schools have for maintaining legacy admissions?

Answer:Ivy League schools believe that accepting legacies at a higher rate fosters loyalty among alumni, who tend to become the institution's biggest donors over time, thus benefiting the school economically in the long run.

4.Question

What historical events influenced legacy admissions policies at Ivy League schools?

Answer:In the late 1960s and early 1970s, efforts to reduce legacy admissions sparked a backlash from alumni, leading schools like Princeton and Yale to retain or restore legacy policies due to pressure from their alumni community.

5.Question

Is it fair to give legacies an advantage in college admissions?

Answer:The author suggests that while a small boost for

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legacies may be reasonable, the current practice of significantly higher acceptance rates (two to three times that of non-legacies) may be excessive.

6.Question

How can prospective students utilize legacy policies when applying to colleges?

Answer:Prospective students should be aware of which colleges consider them as legacies and leverage that knowledge to improve their chances of admission.

7.Question

How does legacy status affect the overall diversity of the student body at Ivy League schools?

Answer:Given that a significant portion of the admits are legacies, this can impact the diversity of the student body, as legacies often come from families that have been educated at these institutions, potentially limiting opportunities for first-time college attendees from diverse backgrounds.

8.Question

What are the implications of legacy admissions on non-legacy applicants?

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Answer: Non-legacy applicants, especially those with strong academic profiles, may be overlooked in favor of legacies, creating perceptions of unfairness and potentially dissuading highly-qualified candidates from applying to these elite institutions.

9.Question

How has the acceptance rate for legacies changed at Harvard with changes in admission policies?

Answer: After changing its policies and moving to a 'regular only' admission process in 2008, Harvard's overall acceptance rate dropped significantly to 7%, resulting in fewer legacy admits as well.

10.Question

What role do financial contributions play in legacy admissions?

Answer: While financial contributions do play a role, particularly amongst major donors, the primary rationale for legacy preferences is the long-term relationship and loyalty between alumni and their alma mater, rather than immediate

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Chapter 13 | 13. Flags and Tags: Special Talents| Q&A

1.Question

What special talents do Ivy League schools look for in applicants?

Answer:The Ivies consider talents in music, dance, and visual arts such as photography. They assess these talents through a rating scale specific to each college, often involving evaluations from respective departments.

2.Question

Why is it important to only send additional materials if you are extremely talented?

Answer:Sending materials when you are not exceptionally skilled can backfire, as admissions committees are inundated with submissions and will judge you against serious competitors with years of experience.

3.Question

How can a strong endorsement from a music department influence an application?

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Answer: A high rating and a strong endorsement from a professor can significantly enhance an application, especially if the professor expresses the need for the student's talent in their program.

4.Question

When should you not send supplementary materials for your special talent?

Answer: You should refrain from sending additional materials if you are an amateur in your talent area or if your skills are mediocre, as you would not stand out compared to more experienced artists.

5.Question

What should you include in your application if you want to highlight your special talents?

Answer: List your special talents clearly in your application. If you have notable achievements or awards, mention them, but avoid sending actual materials unless you are confident in the exceptional quality of your work.

6.Question

How important is the combination of academic

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performance and special talent in college admissions?

Answer: The combination can be crucial; for students with already high academic rankings, a special talent can enhance their application profile, while for those with average academics, a special talent might provide a needed boost to their chances.

7.Question

What is the main takeaway regarding special talents and their impact on college admissions?

Answer: Applicants should strategically present their special talents, ensuring they reflect seriously on their skills and how they align with their potential college involvement. Honest presentation and quality are key.

Chapter 14 | 14. Flags and Tags: Development/ VIP Cases| Q&A

1.Question

What does development mean in the context of college admissions?

Answer: In college admissions, development refers to the practice where wealthy individuals or families

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offer significant financial donations to a college or university in exchange for favorable consideration for their child's acceptance. These donations typically amount to millions of dollars, rather than just a few thousand.

2.Question

How does a development flag impact a student's application?

Answer:A development flag is a numerical code added to a student's application file, indicating that they come from a family willing to make a large donation to the institution.

While this may increase their chances of admission slightly, it still requires the student to meet a certain academic standard, generally a GPA of 4.0 or above.

3.Question

Do development cases make up a significant portion of college admissions?

Answer:No, development cases account for a very small percentage of admissions. For example, at Dartmouth, only

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about 30 out of 11,400 applications were on the full development list, resulting in less than 1 percent of incoming freshmen being admitted mainly due to their parents' contributions.

4.Question

What is the role of the director of admissions regarding development cases?

Answer:The director of admissions has complete control over the admitted class and can choose to accept or reject development cases. Their philosophy about admitting students based on donations can vary; for instance, Dartmouth's director was known for being strict and not accepting subpar students just because of a family's giving potential.

5.Question

How does the admissions process differ for celebrities compared to regular applicants?

Answer:Celebrity children often receive a VIP label in their applications, making them more desirable candidates for

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colleges. Such applicants, like the children of high-profile figures, might attract media attention and funding for the college. However, they still undergo the standard admissions process and their final acceptance is at the director's discretion.

6.Question

What kind of influence do donations have on college admissions across different universities?

Answer: While donations can influence admissions, the extent varies by institution. Schools like Duke may accept 100 to 125 students based on family wealth or connections, while others, like Dartmouth, are more stringent. Some elites like Harvard may facilitate this process more than others.

7.Question

What should parents do if they believe their family qualifies as a development case?

Answer: Parents should reach out to the college's alumni affairs or development office, as they often compile the official list of development cases submitted to the admissions

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office. However, the ultimate decision still lies with the director of admissions.

8.Question

How does Daniel Golden's book 'The Price of Admission' contribute to the understanding of college admissions?

Answer:Daniel Golden's book explores the complexities of how wealth and influence can facilitate entry into elite colleges. It provides real-life examples of how donations affect admissions decisions and elaborates on the disparity faced by students from less affluent backgrounds.

Chapter 15 | 15. Flags and Tags: Faculty and Trustee Recommendations| Q&A

1.Question

How significant are faculty or trustee recommendations in the college admissions process?

Answer:Faculty or trustee recommendations can provide some extra consideration during the admissions process, but they are not a guaranteed path to acceptance unless the applicant is already a strong candidate. For instance, a compelling letter

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from a professor impressed by a student's research work is more impactful than a vague recommendation from a family friend.

2.Question

What kind of recommendation carries more weight, personal achievements or connections?

Answer:Personal achievements carry more weight.

Admissions committees prefer to see strong academic performance and genuine endorsements crafted from meaningful interactions rather than connections from influential individuals who don't know the applicant well.

3.Question

What should applicants avoid when seeking letters of recommendation?

Answer:Applicants should avoid seeking recommendations from prominent individuals who do not personally know them. Such letters can appear insincere and reflect insecurity about the applicant's abilities, rather than showcasing genuine merit.

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4.Question

What can applicants do to strengthen their applications beyond recommendations?

Answer:Applicants should focus on showcasing their academic achievements and unique skills, allowing these fundamental strengths to stand at the forefront of their applications, rather than relying on external endorsements.

5.Question

What is the risk of name-dropping in college applications?

Answer:Name-dropping can backfire, negatively impacting how admissions officers perceive the applicant. It may suggest that the student lacks confidence in their own qualifications and relies on privilege rather than personal merit.

6.Question

Can you provide an example of a more effective recommendation scenario?

Answer:An example of an effective recommendation would be a professor who has closely supervised a student's

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research project and can enthusiastically discuss their contributions and intellect, thus providing a vivid portrayal of the student's capabilities and character.

7.Question

Why is it important for recommendations to be sincere and genuine?

Answer:Sincere recommendations give admissions officers true insights into an applicant's character and potential, reinforcing the applicant's fit for the institution. They highlight the student's achievements and qualities that align with the college's values.

8.Question

How do elite colleges like Dartmouth view letters from influential figures?

Answer:Elite colleges like Dartmouth are stringent regarding recommendations from influential figures. They prefer endorsements that are rooted in meaningful connections and genuine knowledge of the applicant's abilities. Superficial letters from names with no real insight into the candidate

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may harm rather than help.

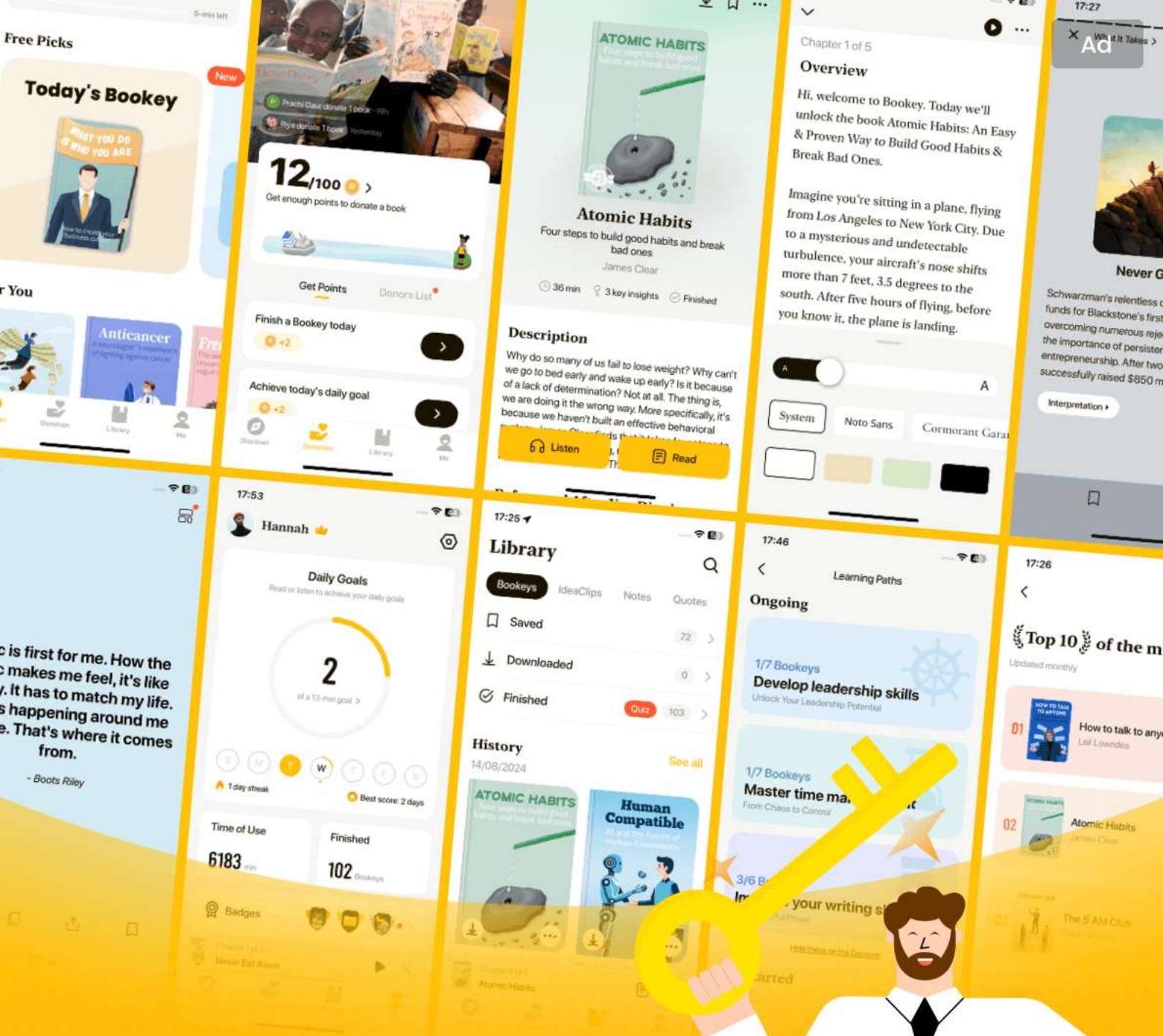
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Chapter 16 | 16. Flags and Tags: Minority Recruiting| Q&A

1.Question

What does minority recruiting mean in the context of college admissions?

Answer:Minority recruiting refers to the efforts made by colleges, particularly the Ivy League schools, to attract and admit students from traditionally underrepresented racial and ethnic groups. This includes black, Hispanic, Native American, and sometimes other groups deemed as minorities. The goal is to enhance diversity on campus, which is seen as beneficial for educational experiences. However, the implications and methods of this recruiting can be complex and often misunderstood.

2.Question

Why is the term 'minority' considered imprecise in college admissions discussions?

Answer:The term 'minority' is often misrepresented because

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it encompasses a variety of groups that may not share the same experiences or backgrounds. For instance, it may refer to U.S. citizens of African descent, Hispanic origin from diverse countries, and even include international students from countries like Nigeria or Jamaica, which complicates the idea of representation and the original intent behind affirmative action.

3.Question

How do universities balance the goals of affirmative action and equal opportunity?

Answer:Universities face the challenge of ensuring equal opportunity for all applicants while also addressing historical injustices through affirmative action. This balance is complicated, as it sometimes leads to a situation where less favorable admissions criteria are applied to minority applicants compared to white candidates, particularly in cases where socioeconomic background plays a significant role.

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Can you explain the different treatments of minority applicants vs. non-minority applicants?

Answer: Minority applicants may have more lenient admissions standards compared to non-minority applicants. For example, a minority student with lower test scores and class rank may still be admitted if they demonstrate potential and face challenges in their background. In contrast, a non-minority applicant typically needs higher standardized test scores and class rankings to be considered, creating a disparity in the admissions process.

5.Question

What impact does socioeconomic status have on college admissions?

Answer: Socioeconomic status plays a critical role in college admissions as it is taken into account when evaluating applicants. Colleges are increasingly seeking to diversify their student population by considering not just race but also the social and economic barriers students have faced. This means that first-generation college students or those from

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low-income backgrounds often receive favorable consideration even if their metrics are not as strong as those from wealthier backgrounds.

6.Question

How does the recruitment of minority students affect diversity on campus?

Answer:Recruitment of minority students is intended to foster a diverse educational environment where varied perspectives enrich learning. However,colleges often prioritize numerical diversity without necessarily ensuring those students will contribute uniquely or authentically to the diversity narrative. This can sometimes lead to a superficial appearance of diversity, where the race or background of students may be highlighted over their individual experiences or contributions.

7.Question

Why is it important to understand the complexities of college admissions related to diversity?

Answer:Understanding the complexities of college

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admissions in relation to diversity helps demystify the process and clarifies the motivations behind admission strategies. It reveals that admissions decisions are not strictly based on merit but are influenced by broader societal goals, historical contexts, and institutional policies. This insight can assist prospective students in critically evaluating their applications and understanding the weight that different aspects of their identity may carry in admissions decisions.

8.Question

What are some of the criticisms related to the way colleges implement affirmative action?

Answer: Critics argue that colleges often misuse affirmative action as a means to appear diverse while still primarily admitting affluent students who fit into desired diversity categories, such as children of well-educated immigrants. This raises questions about whether the policies truly promote equal opportunity or simply perpetuate existing privileges under the guise of fostering diversity.

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How does the emphasis on diversity impact the admission outcomes for Asian-American students?

Answer: Asian-American applicants often face a unique challenge in admissions processes because, despite being classified as a minority, they may encounter higher standards and admission rates skewed against them due to their high academic performance. This creates a situation where they need to achieve higher test scores or class ranks to gain admission compared to other racial or ethnic groups, raising concerns over equity and fairness in the admissions process.

10.Question

What is the significance of understanding your own background in the college application process?

Answer: Being aware of your background can influence how you present your application, as admissions committees often evaluate applicants through the lens of their experiences and challenges. Understanding your socioeconomic and educational context can empower you to articulate your story effectively, showcasing how your background has shaped

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your achievements and aspirations, ultimately enhancing your candidacy.

Chapter 17 | 17. Summary of All Tip Factors and Geographic Diversity| Q&A

1.Question

What are 'tip factors' in college admissions and how do they affect acceptance rates?

Answer:Tip factors are aspects of an applicant's profile that may positively influence their admissions decision. These include being a legacy, an athlete, or belonging to a minority group. For instance, at Dartmouth, legacy applicants have a 40% acceptance rate, while recruited athletes enjoy a 60% acceptance rate. However, tip factors do not solely favor minority applicants; a range of applicants can benefit from them. Ultimately, the majority of admitted students (61%) gain acceptance based solely on academic merit, which is crucial to note.

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How does geographic diversity impact college admissions?

Answer: Geographic diversity is considered by colleges, but it does not significantly influence admissions decisions. For example, acceptance rates across states exhibit little variance. Students from different regions do not have an advantage based on geographic location; it is the strength of the application that matters. Even in states with fewer applicants, like South Dakota, if the academic qualifications are not competitive, the chances of acceptance can be low.

3.Question

Is it true that students from high schools with many applicants face lower acceptance rates?

Answer: No, high schools with many applicants generally see higher acceptance rates. Admissions officers evaluate students in relation to their peers but do not consider their high school grouping until the end of the process. For instance, Stuyvesant High School has a high acceptance rate because its applicants are often top-tier students, showing

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that a competitive high school can yield many qualified candidates.

4.Question

How do private and public school acceptance rates compare at Ivy League colleges?

Answer:Acceptance rates between private and public high schools are statistically similar at Ivy League colleges.

Although private prep schools may report high percentages of their students attending Ivy League institutions, the acceptance rates for their applicants do not necessarily outperform those from top public schools. Both types of schools provide a competitively qualified applicant pool.

5.Question

Why might families believe that geographic diversity and high school prestige play a critical role in admissions?

Answer:Families may believe in the importance of geographic diversity and high school prestige due to common misconceptions. Some think that being from a less competitive state or attending a prestigious private school

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gives an advantage, but data shows that admissions decisions are more influenced by individual academic qualifications and merits rather than external factors like location or school type.

6.Question

What should applicants focus on to enhance their chances of admission?

Answer: Applicants should concentrate on factors within their control, primarily their academic achievements and application content. Striving for excellence in coursework, standardized test scores, leadership roles, and community involvement can significantly improve chances of acceptance, regardless of background or geographical location.

7.Question

What is the importance of how strong an applicant is over where they come from?

Answer: The strength of an applicant's profile is paramount in college admissions. A talented student will stand out

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regardless of their origin, as demonstrated through acceptance rates that show minimal fluctuation based on geography or high school. Thus, high academic performance remains the most crucial aspect for college admissions.

8.Question

What can students and parents take away from the statistics on acceptance rates of various demographics?

Answer:The key takeaway is that while certain groups benefit from tip factors, the majority of admittees at competitive colleges are those who excel academically without those advantages. Understanding this can help many applicants focus their efforts on what truly impacts admissions outcomes.

Chapter 18 | 18. The Postgraduate Year| Q&A

1.Question

What is a postgraduate year, and who might benefit from it?

Answer:A postgraduate year (PG year) is an extra year of high school that some students choose to take

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before heading to college. It is particularly beneficial for those who may not feel academically prepared for college, are young for their grade, or have mediocre grades and wish to enhance their academic record. For example, a late-blooming student with low grades from the regular high school years might attend a private prep school during the PG year to demonstrate their ability to handle rigorous academic coursework.

2.Question

How does a postgraduate year affect Ivy League recruited athletes compared to non-athletes?

Answer:For Ivy League recruited athletes, a PG year can significantly benefit their admission prospects by allowing them to improve their academic standing without being penalized for previous years' grades, at least until 1997 when rules changed to average the PG year with high school years. In contrast, non-athlete Ivy League applicants or applicants to non-Ivy selective colleges will not have their earlier

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records entirely erased by a strong PG year; their four-year GPA will still be a heavy factor in their admissions chances.

3.Question

What misconceptions might students have about the impact of a postgraduate year on their college applications?

Answer:Many students might believe that a strong performance during a PG year can completely override a weak four-year high school record. However, admissions officers typically consider the entire academic history, and unless there is a compelling narrative or significant improvement, one good PG year usually won't erase previous academic deficiencies.

4.Question

What are some considerations students should keep in mind before deciding to pursue a postgraduate year?

Answer:Students should carefully assess whether they truly need an extra year to enhance their readiness for college. They should consider the potential financial implications, the quality of the PG program, and understand how colleges

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view such a year. Ultimately, it's crucial to recognize that while a PG year can be advantageous, it is not a 'get out of jail free card' for poor previous performance.

5.Question

What role do admissions officers play in evaluating a postgraduate year?

Answer:Admissions officers play a critical role in evaluating a PG year by assessing the student's overall academic trajectory, including the contrast between the high school performance and the PG year. They take into account grades, course rigor, and personal testimonials to form a holistic view, rather than focusing solely on the most recent academic year.

6.Question

Can a postgraduate year ensure admission into a selective college?

Answer:No, while it may boost a student's chances, a PG year does not guarantee admission into a selective college. Factors like the overall academic record, recommendations,

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extracurricular activities, and personal statements all contribute significantly to the admission decision.

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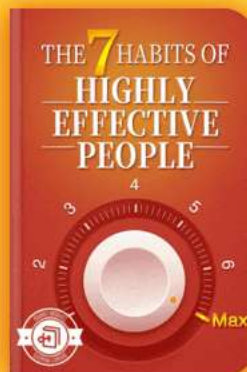
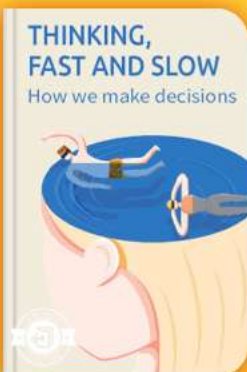


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Chapter 19 | 19. Postacceptance and Beyond| Q&A

1.Question

What are the consequences of slacking off after college acceptance?

Answer:Slacking off after college acceptance can lead to a significant drop in grades, which may cause colleges to reconsider their acceptance. Teachers, who supported you throughout your application process, may feel disappointed and could withdraw their support. Furthermore, if academic performance declines too much, the college may send warning letters, and in severe cases, students might lose their admission.

2.Question

How does sustaining academic effort affect teachers and personal pride?

Answer:Maintaining academic effort shows respect for the teachers who supported you, reinforcing your commitment to education. It reflects your passion for learning and helps

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preserve the goodwill of mentors who have invested in your success. This diligence also contributes to personal pride, as finishing strong in your studies helps you enter college on a positive note.

3.Question

Why is it beneficial to continue working hard in AP classes even after acceptance?

Answer:Continuing to work hard in AP classes can earn you college credit, saving money on tuition costs. For instance, scoring high on AP exams can translate into credits at Dartmouth, allowing you to take fewer classes and possibly graduate early, thereby saving thousands of dollars.

4.Question

What should students consider before allowing their grades to drop in senior year?

Answer:Students should consider the potential impact on their college acceptance, the disappointment it may cause for their teachers and family, as well as the financial consequences linked to college admissions related to AP

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credits. The risk of being placed on academic probation is another significant factor. It's vital to weigh these consequences against the temporary relief from academic pressure.

5.Question

How does the admissions office monitor student performance after acceptance?

Answer:Colleges, like Dartmouth, actively monitor accepted students' senior year grades. Admissions officers review transcripts for any significant academic decline, and they may send warning letters if grades drop considerably. This monitoring continues into the students'first year, which emphasizes the importance of maintaining a strong academic record.

6.Question

What can students do to avoid the 'senior slump' phenomenon?

Answer:To avoid the senior slump, students should stay engaged in their studies, continue challenging themselves

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academically, and finish the school year strong. Taking advantage of Advanced Placement classes and striving to achieve high grades serve as motivations to maintain a disciplined approach to education up until graduation.

Chapter 20 | 20. The Wait List| Q&A

1.Question

What should a student do first if they find themselves on a college's wait list?

Answer:The first thing a student should do is to ascertain whether they still wish to remain on the wait list. This often involves responding to a card or communication from the college that asks if they want to stay on the list. Confirming their interest helps signal to the college that they are still motivated.

2.Question

How does being on a college's wait list reflect on the strength of an applicant?

Answer:Being on a college's wait list, especially for

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institutions like Dartmouth, indicates that the applicant was very close to being accepted; they received more acceptance and wait-list votes than rejection votes in committee, showcasing their strong candidacy. Many who end up on the wait list are often among the top applicants.

3.Question

What is the norm for colleges like Dartmouth in terms of accepting students from the wait list?

Answer:Dartmouth typically accepts between fifty to one hundred students from the wait list, depending on factors like summer attrition and overall yield from the initial accepting students.

4.Question

Should students on the wait list send in additional materials like extra recommendations?

Answer:No, students should not inundate college offices with extra materials, as it can annoy admissions officers. Instead, they should ensure that all powerful recommendations and achievements are included in their original application.

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5.Question

What strategy should a student use if they want to express their continued interest to a college while on the wait list?

Answer:A student may ask their guidance counselor to reach out to the college, emphasizing the student's strong interest in attending, particularly if they have other offers from competitive schools.

6.Question

How does a college decide who to accept from the wait list?

Answer:Colleges typically review 'hot' wait-list candidates, using recommendations from regional officers who highlight standout applicants from their regions. The admissions director ultimately makes the final decisions based on these recommendations and the overall strength of candidates.

7.Question

Is it advisable for parents to call admissions offices about their child's wait list status?

Answer:Parents should generally avoid calling admissions offices unless they have significant information to provide.

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It's better for guidance counselors to communicate on behalf of students when necessary.

8.Question

What does being admitted off the wait list suggest about an applicant?

Answer:Being accepted from the wait list means the college considers the student a top candidate, regardless of the timing of their admission notification. This reflects well on the student's qualifications and potential.

9.Question

What can students learn from the experiences of those on wait lists at very selective colleges?

Answer:Students can understand that rejection or wait-list status at highly selective colleges does not diminish their achievements—many strong candidates cannot be admitted due to limited spaces. It underscores the competitive nature of admissions and the importance of resilience in the process.

Chapter 21 | 21. Communication Among Schools| Q&A

1.Question

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What can you learn about the culture of college admissions from the author's experience?

Answer: The author reveals that the culture of college admissions, especially within highly selective colleges like the Ivies, does not involve conspiracy or collaboration among colleges as many students might believe. Instead, admissions officers are busy managing high volumes of applications independently and are primarily focused on evaluating candidates rather than comparing or discussing them with other institutions. This suggests that the admissions process is more about individual merit and less about competition between colleges.

2.Question

Why is it important for students to understand the rules regarding early decision and early action applications?

Answer: Understanding the rules surrounding early decision and early action is crucial for students because failing to

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adhere to these guidelines can lead to serious consequences, such as the withdrawal of acceptance offers. The narrative emphasizes that students must honor commitments made in early decision applications, as colleges communicate with each other to ensure compliance. This underscores the importance of making informed, strategic choices in the admissions process.

3.Question

How does the author describe interactions and communication among admissions officers at Ivy League schools?

Answer: Interactions among admissions officers at Ivy League schools are depicted as minimal and informal, primarily occurring during a few annual conferences where officers attend various meetings. The author describes these gatherings more as social opportunities than productive work sessions, illustrating that there is little real-time communication or collaboration throughout the application review period. This reflects the individualistic nature of the

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admissions process.

4.Question

What should students take away about how colleges perceive applicants?

Answer:Students should take away that colleges do not attempt to second-guess applicants' preferences or aspirations. Admissions decisions are made based on the applicant's qualifications and not influenced by speculation regarding other applications or college choices. This imparts the idea that students should focus on presenting their best selves in their applications without concern for what other colleges might think.

5.Question

How does the author conclude the section regarding the myth of college recruitment strategies?

Answer:The author concludes by dispelling the myth that colleges engage in strategic recruitment competition against each other. Instead, the primary focus of college admissions is to efficiently process and evaluate a myriad of applications

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without the influence of perceived or conjectured rivalries. This conclusion reinforces that students' applications are assessed on their individual merits.

6.Question

What advice does the author give to alleviate students' fears about communication among colleges?

Answer: The author advises students to put their fears to rest regarding communication among colleges, emphasizing that such communication does not occur and that colleges are far too preoccupied with their own admissions processes.

Students should concentrate on their own applications and ensure they follow the established rules, rather than worrying about what other colleges might know or do.

7.Question

Why is it crucial for students to ensure their applications reflect their true intentions and interests?

Answer: It is crucial for students to reflect their true intentions and interests in their applications because misleading information can lead to complications, such as

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being deemed inactive by other colleges. This reinforces the importance of honesty and clarity in communication with colleges to avoid situations that might jeopardize their acceptance.

8.Question

What role do yield rates play in the admissions process according to the author?

Answer: Yield rates play a significant role in the admissions process as they help colleges predict how many accepted students will ultimately enroll. The author explains that schools will admit a certain number of students based on expected yield percentages, ensuring they fill their class when the actual enrollment occurs. This statistical aspect influences how colleges approach admissions and helps them manage their enrollment goals.

9.Question

How can understanding the dynamics of college admissions reduce stress for students?

Answer: By understanding that admission officers operate in

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a busy environment with little communication among colleges, students can alleviate the stress of thinking they are being compared or scrutinized by various institutions. Recognizing that the process hinges more on individual application strength rather than external scrutiny can help students feel empowered and focused on their unique qualifications.

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Chapter 22 | 22. Financial-Aid Implications and International Students| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to understand the financial aid implications when applying to colleges, especially for Ivy League institutions?

Answer: Understanding financial aid implications is crucial because it can significantly impact your chances of admission. Ivy League schools are categorized as need-blind for U.S. students, meaning financial need does not influence admission decisions. However, for international students, the dynamics change. Students applying for financial aid are often subjected to a different set of standards and evaluations than their peers who can pay full tuition. Hence, applicants must carefully consider whether to apply for financial aid based on their specific circumstances and the college's policies.

2.Question

What does 'need-blind' mean in the context of college

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admissions and how does it vary among schools?

Answer: 'Need-blind' means that a college makes admission decisions without regard to a student's financial situation.

Most Ivy League schools follow this policy for U.S. citizens, meaning that an applicant's ability to pay does not affect their admission. However, not all highly selective colleges are entirely need-blind, and some may use financial need in their decision-making process, creating disparities in how applicants are evaluated.

3.Question

What are the new financial aid initiatives mentioned in the chapter, and how have they changed the application landscape for low and middle-income families?

Answer: The chapter highlights significant shifts initiated by schools like Harvard, Yale, and Dartmouth in 2007, designed to attract lower and middle-income families. For example, Harvard announced that families earning between \$120,000 to \$180,000 would only pay 10% of their income towards tuition, while also eliminating student loans, replacing them

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with grants. These initiatives have made higher education more accessible to a broader range of families, particularly those who previously felt squeezed by financial constraints.

4.Question

How does the application for financial aid impact international students differently than U.S. students?

Answer:Unlike U.S. students, international students cannot be read on a need-blind basis due to limited financial aid budgets for non-citizens. This means international applicants indicating they need financial aid may face harsher scrutiny in the admissions process, often resulting in lower chances of acceptance compared to those who do not require financial assistance.

5.Question

What are the advantages and disadvantages of applying for financial aid as an international student?

Answer:The advantage of applying for financial aid as an international student is that some schools may offer generous packages to attract non-college background students.

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However, the disadvantage is that applications for financial aid can lead to increased competition and, in many cases, a higher likelihood of rejection compared to peers who do not need aid, since available financial resources are often limited.

6.Question

What ethical considerations should applicants keep in mind regarding applying for financial aid?

Answer:Applicants should approach the financial aid process with honesty and integrity. It's essential to apply for aid based on genuine need, as attempting to manipulate the system could undermine the applicant's credibility and ultimately harm their chances for admission. Upholding ethical standards is vital to ensure that one does not compromise their values or those of the institution.

7.Question

What is the significance of standardized test scores and socioeconomic background in the admissions process?

Answer:Standardized test scores are assessed in conjunction with the applicant's socioeconomic background. Students

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from less privileged backgrounds may receive some leniency in testing standards, while those from more affluent backgrounds may face stricter scrutiny. This discriminative approach aims to provide equitable chances to all applicants by acknowledging the disparities in educational access and resources.

8.Question

How have Ivy League schools adjusted their financial aid processes since 2007, particularly in relation to international students?

Answer: Since 2007, some Ivy League schools have increased their financial aid budgets and eliminated loans for low-income families, making it easier for them to afford tuition. Additionally, while Ivy League schools generally remain need-blind for U.S. applicants, they have begun to adopt similar policies for international students, widening the net for those who require aid.

9.Question

What role does the TOEFL play in the admissions process for international students?

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Answer: The TOEFL (Test of English as a Foreign Language) is a crucial requirement for international students as it assesses their proficiency in English. A strong score (above 600) is often essential for admission, especially for students applying for aid. A low score could be a barrier, as it may indicate insufficient English skills to meet academic demands.

10. Question

Why might a student not benefit from being able to pay full tuition when applying to Ivy League schools?

Answer: In Ivy League admissions, the belief that being able to pay full tuition is advantageous is a misconception. Unless a substantial donation is made, financial ability does not enhance an applicant's chances. In fact, not applying for financial aid can sometimes eliminate potential benefits or allowances afforded to those considered economically disadvantaged. Admissions officers may overlook socio-economic context when a student does not apply for aid, potentially neutralizing any perceived advantage of full

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tuition capability.

Chapter 23 | 23. Transfer Students| Q&A

1.Question

What are the primary factors considered for transfer student admissions in Ivy League schools?

Answer:The primary factors considered for transfer student admissions include the student's college grades, the essay explaining their reasons for wanting to transfer, recommendations from professors and advisors, high school records, outside interests, and work experiences. Personal qualities such as creativity and intellectual curiosity are also sought after in applicants.

2.Question

How does the transfer admissions deadline differ from regular admissions?

Answer:Transfer admissions deadlines are generally later in the year, specifically between March first and April first for Ivy League schools, compared to the January first deadline

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for regular decision applicants.

3.Question

Why is it challenging to gain acceptance as a transfer student to Ivy League colleges?

Answer:It is challenging to gain acceptance as a transfer student because Ivy League schools receive a tremendous number of applications during the regular admissions process, and the overall acceptance rate for transfers is much lower than for freshmen.

4.Question

What types of schools do most transfer applicants come from according to the text?

Answer:Most transfer applicants to Ivy League schools do not come from other Ivy League institutions; they are accepted from a wide variety of colleges, including both well-known universities and lesser-known community colleges.

5.Question

What role do personal qualities play in the transfer admissions process?

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Answer: Personal qualities are significant in the transfer admissions process, as admissions staff actively seek qualities like creativity and intellectual curiosity in applicants, indicating that admissions decisions are not solely based on academic records.

6.Question

What unique aspects of the Dartmouth transfer application process are highlighted?

Answer: The Dartmouth transfer application emphasizes the importance of college grades, a personal essay discussing the desire to transfer, and recommendations from current college professors and advisors, while still considering high school records and extracurricular activities.

7.Question

Why might it be beneficial for students to apply for transfer spots, based on the information provided?

Answer: Applying for transfer spots can provide students an opportunity to experience a new academic environment, potentially at a more prestigious institution like an Ivy

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League school, which may offer unique resources and networking opportunities that could enhance their educational and professional prospects.

Chapter 24 | 24. Do You Need an Independent Counselor?| Q&A

1.Question

What are the key indicators that suggest hiring an independent college counselor might be beneficial?

Answer:Consider hiring an independent counselor if: (1) the high school counselor is under-qualified; (2) the counselor has a large caseload preventing individualized attention; (3) the student has special needs or struggles with writing; (4) the student possesses unique talents requiring specialized knowledge; or (5) the parents lack the time or expertise needed for the application process.

2.Question

How early should families consider engaging with an independent counselor?

Answer:Families should engage with an independent

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counselor as early as eighth or ninth grade to ensure proper course selection and preparedness for college applications.

3.Question

What is the primary role of an independent college counselor?

Answer:The primary role of an independent college counselor is to understand the student's interests and ambitions, provide guidance on course selection, and align the student's achievements with appropriate colleges.

4.Question

Why is the relationship between students and their high school counselors important?

Answer:The relationship is important because a better understanding leads to more personalized recommendations and insights that are critical for college applications. High school counselors provide context on the student's rankings and relationships within the school, information that independent counselors generally do not have access to.

5.Question

What potential pitfalls should parents avoid when

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working with independent counselors?

Answer: Parents should avoid assuming independent counselors can guarantee acceptance into top colleges, and they should ensure that these counselors do not infringe on ethical boundaries by writing essays or making inappropriate contacts with admissions offices.

6.Question

What is a common misconception about the effectiveness of independent counselors?

Answer: A common misconception is that hiring an independent counselor alone can secure college admissions. In reality, only students can determine their own success through their abilities and efforts.

7.Question

Describe an analogy used in the chapter to explain the role of independent counselors in the college admissions process.

Answer: An analogy used is that of dressing up vanilla ice cream with toppings. Despite the dressing, the fundamental

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quality of the vanilla ice cream remains the same, highlighting that counselors cannot create talent or intelligence; these attributes must come from the student.

8.Question

How should parents manage the perception of using an independent counselor regarding their child's college application?

Answer:Parents should be discreet about using an independent counselor, as public knowledge of hiring a consultant may lead admissions officers to question the student's self-sufficiency and capabilities.

9.Question

What should be the approach of the best independent counselors in terms of college admissions ethics?

Answer:The best independent counselors maintain a low profile, do not contact colleges on behalf of students, and focus on supporting students without overtly influencing the admissions process.

10.Question

What is the author's perspective on the role of

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independent counselors based on her experiences?

Answer: The author believes that while independent counselors can provide significant support and guidance, they cannot perform miracles, and ultimately, the student's own capabilities are what determine admissions outcomes.

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Chapter 25 | 25. The Final Rung of the Ladder: Last-Minute Adjustments| Q&A

1.Question

What do admissions officers consider during the last-minute adjustments of applications?

Answer:During the last-minute adjustments, admissions officers review student applications school by school to catch any potential inequities. They use a docket listing to compare applicants from the same high school, ensuring that decisions are fair and taking into account special categories such as socioeconomic circumstances or athletic recruitment.

2.Question

How do admissions officers handle cases where a lower-ranked student is accepted over a higher-ranked student?

Answer:In such cases, if a lower-ranked student is accepted, it is typically due to special considerations like athletic recruits or unique circumstances. Admissions officers must

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present their decisions to a director, who has the final say, and often the rationale behind these decisions is not disclosed to parents.

3.Question

Why might it be difficult for parents to understand admissions decisions?

Answer:Parents often struggle to grasp the complexities of admissions decisions because the reasons behind accepting a lower-ranked student are nuanced and not shared publicly. They may focus solely on rankings without recognizing other factors like test scores or the student's overall impression during the evaluation process.

4.Question

What is 'docket review' and why is it important?

Answer:Docket review is a process where regional officers review all applications from their regions to identify and address any inconsistencies or inequities. It is important because it helps ensure fairness in the admissions process and allows the officers to catch any problematic cases before

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final decisions are made.

5.Question

How do admissions officers balance fairness with institutional priorities?

Answer:Admissions officers strive for fairness while also fulfilling institutional priorities by considering various categories of applicants, such as legacies and minority students. This balancing act can lead to situations that may seem inequitable at first glance, but serve broader goals for the institution.

6.Question

What role do guidance counselors play in the admissions process?

Answer:Guidance counselors play a significant role in helping students understand the admissions process. They generally understand that certain lower-ranked students may be accepted due to special circumstances, like sports recruitment, and can assist families in navigating their expectations.

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7.Question

Why can't admissions offices disclose specific reasons for a student's acceptance or rejection?

Answer:Admissions offices cannot disclose specific reasons for decisions to protect the privacy of applicants and maintain the integrity of the admissions process. Each decision often involves a combination of factors that cannot be fully communicated without jeopardizing individual confidentiality.

8.Question

What are the emotions involved in admissions decisions for applicants and their families?

Answer:Emotions can run high during admissions decisions, especially for families who feel that their top-ranked child has been unfairly rejected. The disappointment and confusion can lead to anger and frustration, making it difficult for parents to see the broader context behind admissions decisions.

9.Question

What is the overarching theme of the admissions reading

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and decision-making process outlined in the chapter?

Answer: The overarching theme is the complexity and challenges of the admissions process, where multiple factors, including fairness, personal stories, institutional priorities, and individual evaluations, must be carefully balanced to reach decisions that affect students' futures.

Chapter 26 | 26. Conclusion| Q&A

1.Question

What is the overarching theme presented in the conclusion of Chapter 26 regarding the college admissions process?

Answer: The overarching theme is that while the college admissions process, particularly in highly selective colleges, is complex and can seem inequitable, it is fundamentally a serious and thoughtful endeavor. Admissions officers strive to make fair decisions despite the inherent flaws in quantitative measures such as AI scores. There is a need for continuous reflection and improvement to

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create a more equitable system.

2.Question

What flaws does the author identify in the current admissions formula (AI) used by colleges?

Answer:The author highlights several flaws, including an over-reliance on standardized testing, the inadequate comparison of students from different backgrounds, and a lack of account for intellectual curiosity and other qualitative measures. The AI formula doesn't adequately consider high school performance relative to the school's context or difficulties faced by lower-income students.

3.Question

How does the author suggest improving the admissions process to ensure it's fairer for all students?

Answer:The author suggests several improvements, including using class rank as a primary measure, reducing the weight of standardized test scores, incorporating teacher and counselor ratings, accounting for socioeconomic disadvantages, and recognizing intellectual curiosity. A more

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holistic evaluation process that includes qualitative factors and personal insights is recommended.

4.Question

What role do human judgments play in the college admissions process according to the author?

Answer:The author emphasizes that human judgments are crucial for making nuanced decisions that go beyond mere numbers. While computers can manage data, they cannot assess the unique qualities of applicants, such as their backgrounds and potential contributions to campus life. Therefore, a people-oriented approach will improve the quality of admissions decisions.

5.Question

What is the author's ultimate message to prospective college applicants based on the conclusions from the admissions process?

Answer:The ultimate message is that being well-informed about the admissions process can significantly enhance an applicant's chances of success. Understanding how to present oneself and recognizing what makes an application stand out

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are essential. The author believes that demystifying the admissions process empowers students to navigate it more effectively.

6.Question

How does the author feel about the future of highly selective colleges and their admissions processes?

Answer: The author expresses cautious optimism about the future of admissions processes at highly selective colleges. While challenges remain, there is potential for evolution in the admissions approach to adapt to a changing and increasingly competitive applicant pool, ultimately ensuring that motivated and capable students are recognized and evaluated fairly.

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Chapter 1 | 1. The Target Audience| Quiz and Test

- 1.Ivy League admissions officers are typically highly educated individuals.
- 2.Recent graduates in admissions offices tend to evaluate candidates more positively due to their recent experiences in higher education.
- 3.Wealth and privilege are generally considered advantageous factors in Ivy League admissions.

Chapter 2 | 2. The Timetable Through High School: Is Kindergarten Too Early?| Quiz and Test

- 1.Many parents believe that admission to prestigious nursery schools is essential for future college success.
- 2.Students are encouraged to avoid honors courses to keep their stress level low during high school.
- 3.Engaging in activities like public speaking can help shy students improve their confidence in class participation.

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Chapter 3 | 3. Early-Decision and Early-Action Policies| Quiz and Test

1. Applying early decision is nonbinding and allows students to compare offers from multiple colleges.
2. Harvard, Princeton, and the University of Virginia discontinued their early admissions policies in 2006, which affected application trends.
3. Early-decision candidates enjoy lower acceptance rates compared to regular decision applicants at Dartmouth.

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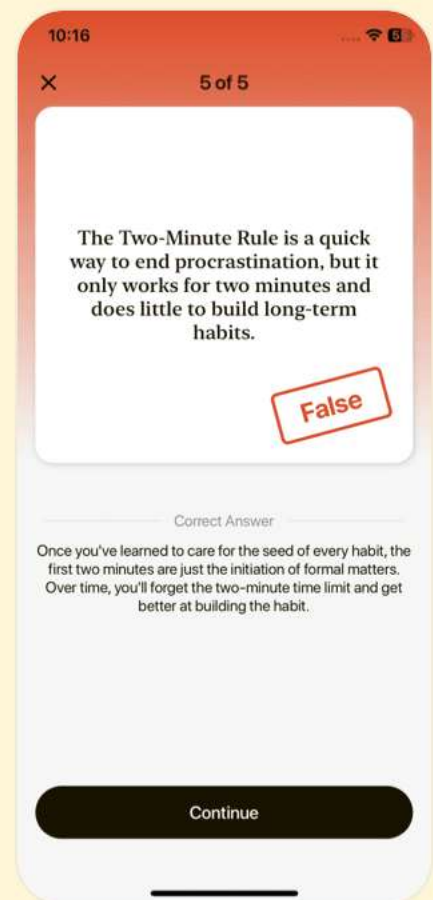
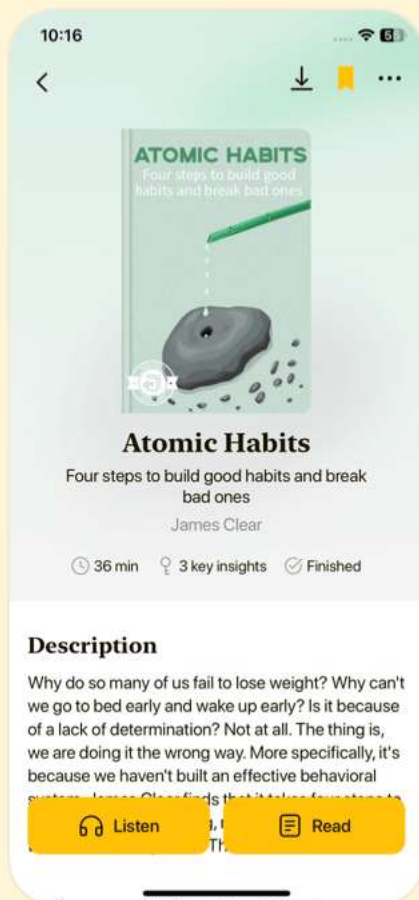


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Chapter 4 | 4. The New SAT and the ACT and Recentering| Quiz and Test

- 1.The SAT scoring system has remained unchanged since its inception.
- 2.The average admitted SAT scores for selective schools have risen following the recentering of scores in 1995.
- 3.The ACT gives students the option to submit only their highest scores, known as score choice.

Chapter 5 | 5. The Importance of the SAT Subject Tests| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author argues that SAT Subject Tests may carry greater weight than high school transcripts in college admissions.
- 2.Colleges typically find high school transcripts to be the most reliable indicator of a student's abilities.
- 3.High Scores on SAT Subject Tests are often undervalued in the Ivy League admissions process.

Chapter 6 | 6. The Academic Index (AI)| Quiz and Test

- 1.The Academic Index (AI) is a formula used by Ivy

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League schools to evaluate applicants based solely on their high school grades.

2.The AI includes a student's SAT Reasoning Test scores, SAT Subject Test scores, and a converted rank score (CRS).

3.Admissions officers at Ivy League schools must strictly adhere to the CRS calculations without making adjustments.

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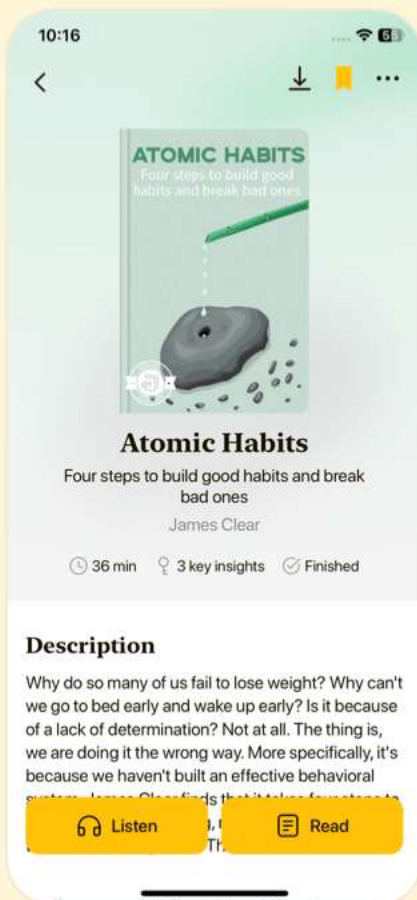


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Chapter 7 | 7. Advanced Placement Scores| Quiz and Test

1. Scoring well on AP or IB tests is not considered an important aspect of a student's academic profile for college admissions.
2. Students are encouraged to take as many AP or IB courses as possible to show their commitment to challenging academic work.
3. AP tests primarily require rote memorization and do not assess deeper analysis or writing skills.

Chapter 8 | 8. The Reading Process| Quiz and Test

1. The admissions process in Ivy League offices begins with a small team sorting and organizing the mail for several weeks.
2. The personal impressions recorded by regional officers have a significant impact on admissions decisions according to the chapter.
3. Top candidates may receive 'likely letters' to indicate probable acceptance to the institution.



Chapter 9 | 9. A Step-by-Step Look at How Your Application Is Read and a Brief Look at the Common Application| Quiz and Test

- 1.The Common Application simplifies the college application process by allowing students to apply to multiple colleges with just one application.
- 2.The personal essay is the least important part of the application and does not influence admissions decisions significantly.
- 3.Admissions officers always rely on standardized test scores to assess an applicant's eligibility and potential.

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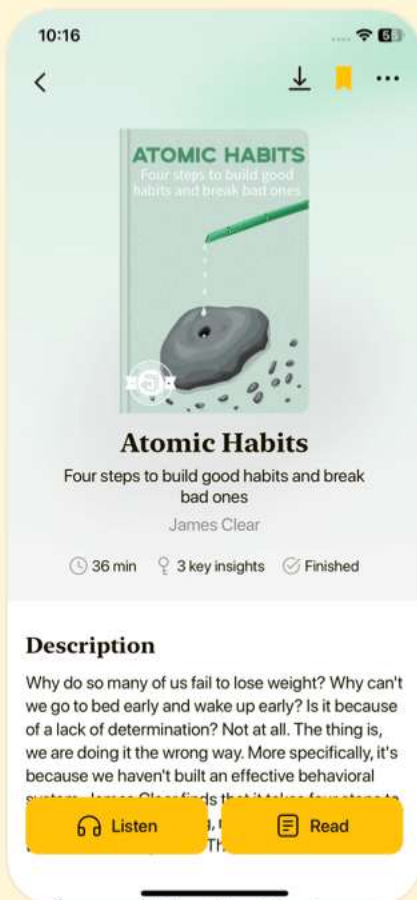


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Chapter 10 | 10. A Brief Trip to the Committee| Quiz and Test

- 1.The committee selection process for college admissions discards both exceptionally strong and weak applications early on.
- 2.All applicants, regardless of their profile, are evaluated by the same committee procedures in the college admissions process.
- 3.The most interesting applicants who demonstrate creativity and curiosity are less likely to gain admission compared to those with strictly strong academic records.

Chapter 11 | 11. Flags and Tags: Athletic Recruiting at the Ivy League Schools| Quiz and Test

- 1.The Ivy League schools offer athletic scholarships to their recruited athletes.
- 2.The Academic Index (AI) is important for determining the admissions chances of recruited athletes in the Ivy League.
- 3.Recruited athletes are accepted at lower rates than the general applicant body at Ivy League schools.

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Chapter 12 | 12. Flags and Tags: Legacies| Quiz and Test

1. A legacy is defined as the child of a graduate from a specific undergraduate institution, such as Dartmouth College.
2. Colleges like Dartmouth and Princeton have a legacy acceptance rate that is significantly lower than the overall acceptance rate.
3. Efforts to reduce legacy admissions in the late 1960s and early 1970s successfully eliminated legacy preferences at Ivy League schools.

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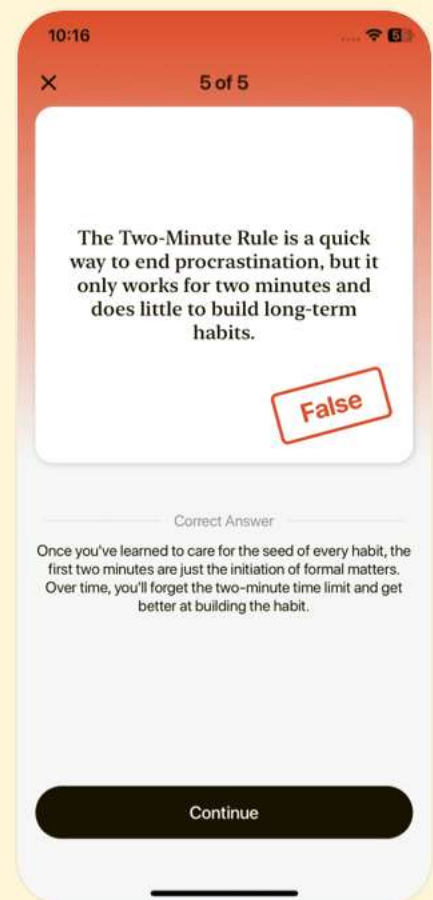
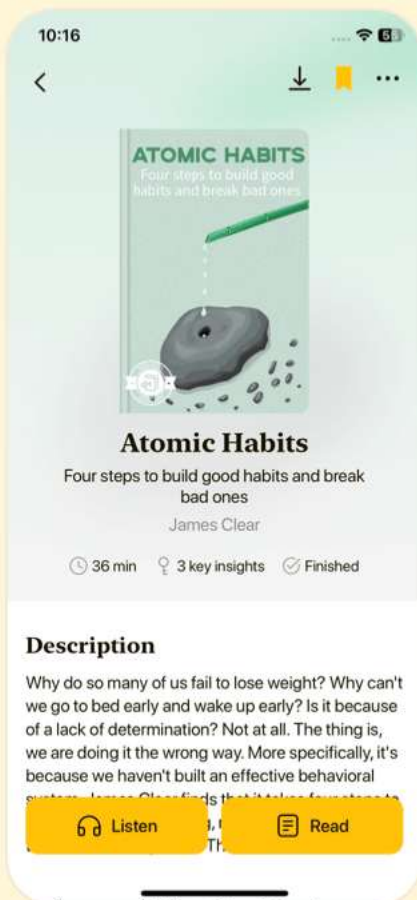


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Chapter 13 | 13. Flags and Tags: Special Talents| Quiz and Test

1. Ivy League colleges consider special talents like music, dance, and art/photography as part of their admissions process.
2. Students must always submit physical evidence of their special talents, such as tapes or slides, to be considered for admission.
3. Only students with top-rated academic rankings benefit from having special talents in their applications.

Chapter 14 | 14. Flags and Tags: Development/ VIP Cases| Quiz and Test

1. Development refers to significant financial contributions that may influence college admissions, typically in the millions.
2. At Dartmouth, approximately 30% of the applicants are accepted through development cases.
3. VIP status in college admissions is exclusively reserved for children of political leaders.

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Chapter 15 | 15. Flags and Tags: Faculty and Trustee Recommendations| Quiz and Test

1. Faculty or trustee recommendations can significantly influence the college admissions process.
2. A recommendation letter from a professor who genuinely appreciates your work is more valuable than one from a family friend.
3. Loading applications with letters from prominent figures who do not know the applicant well is advantageous.

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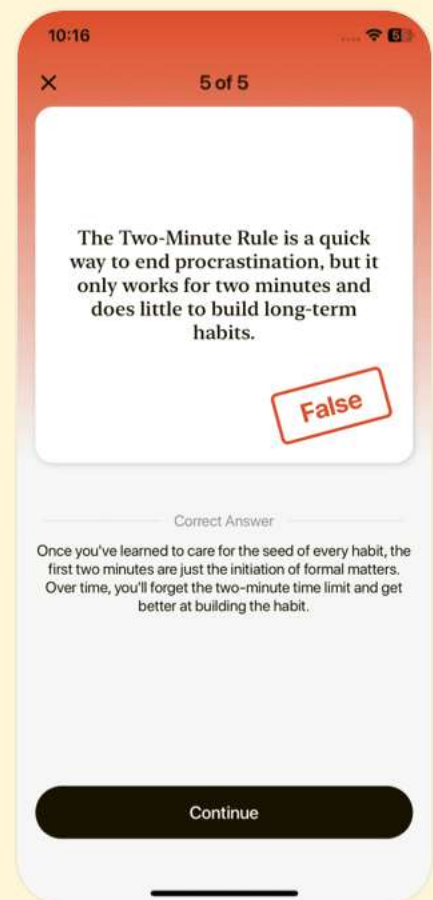
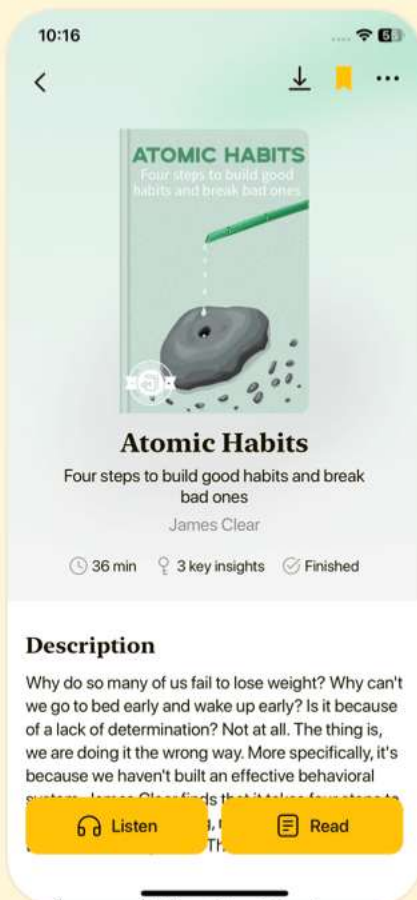


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Chapter 16 | 16. Flags and Tags: Minority Recruiting| Quiz and Test

1. Historically, Ivy League schools predominantly admitted affluent white males.
2. Affirmative action provides equal advantages to all minority groups in college admissions regardless of their socioeconomic status.
3. Asian-American applicants receive specific advantages in Ivy League admissions due to their high achievement levels.

Chapter 17 | 17. Summary of All Tip Factors and Geographic Diversity| Quiz and Test

1. Tip factors influence the admissions decisions for all applicants, not just minorities.
2. Geographic diversity significantly affects an applicant's chance of being admitted to a college.
3. High-achieving public schools have lower acceptance rates compared to elite private schools.

Chapter 18 | 18. The Postgraduate Year| Quiz and Test

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- 1.The postgraduate year (PG year) is commonly known as the 'thirteenth grade' that some students can take before attending college.
- 2.Most public high schools offer a postgraduate year program similar to those found in private institutions.
- 3.Enrollment in a PG year guarantees that students will erase poor grades from high school, leading to successful college admissions.

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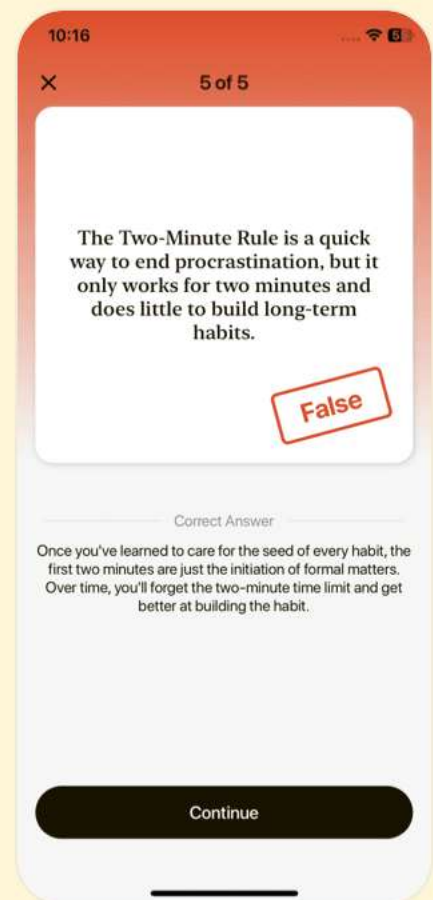
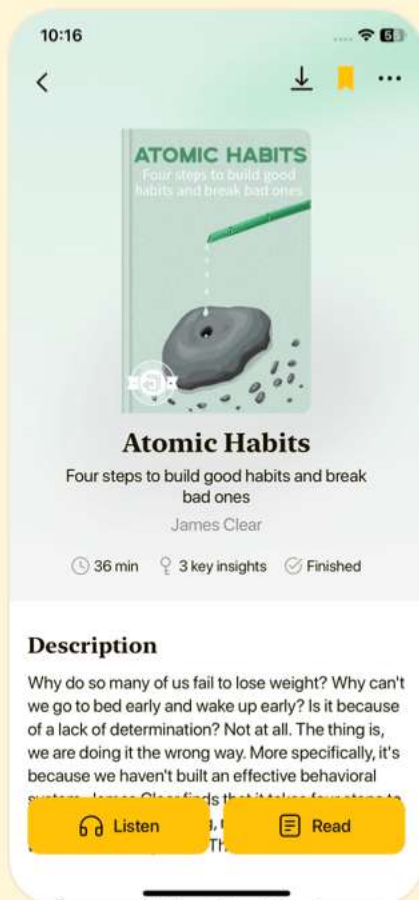


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Chapter 19 | 19. Postacceptance and Beyond| Quiz and Test

1. Students can relax and disengage from their studies once they are accepted into a highly selective college.
2. Colleges monitor accepted students' senior year grades and significant drops can result in rescinded admissions offers.
3. Maintaining good grades in the final year of high school has no impact on a student's future college opportunities.

Chapter 20 | 20. The Wait List| Quiz and Test

1. Each college has the same policies regarding the wait list process.
2. Dartmouth requires candidates to confirm their interest in remaining on the wait list.
3. It is advisable to submit additional materials once you have been wait-listed.

Chapter 21 | 21. Communication Among Schools| Quiz and Test

1. Admissions officers at selective colleges often communicate and conspire about student

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admissions.

2.Ivy League conferences primarily focus on collective decision-making about student admissions.

3.Colleges share individual student information during application reviews.

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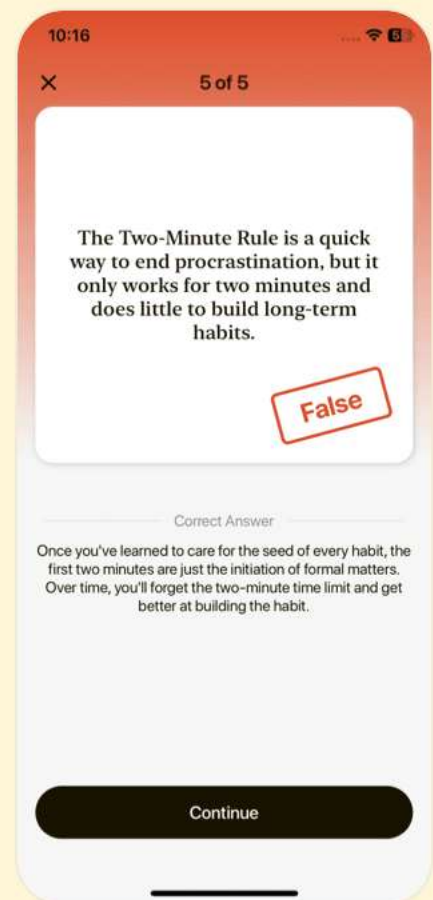
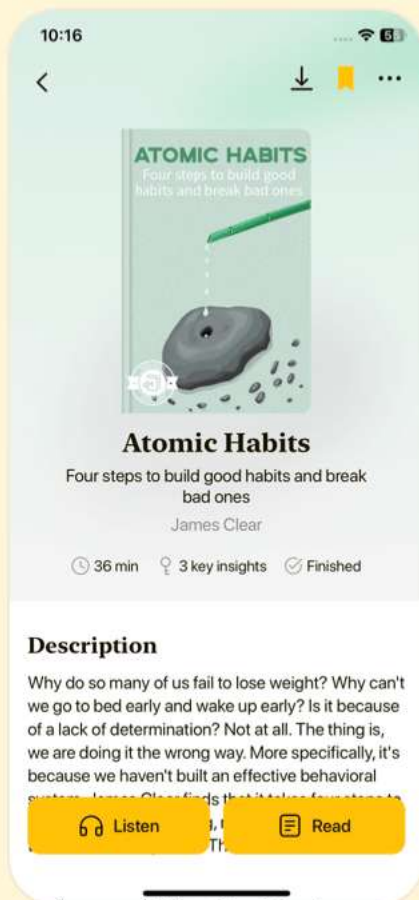


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Chapter 22 | 22. Financial-Aid Implications and International Students| Quiz and Test

1. Applying for financial aid can influence admission decisions in selective colleges for both U.S. citizens and international students.
2. Need-blind admissions policies ensure that financial need does not impact admission decisions for U.S. citizens in Ivy League schools.
3. International students are considered in a need-blind manner when applying for financial aid to colleges.

Chapter 23 | 23. Transfer Students| Quiz and Test

1. Ivy League schools commonly accept a high number of transfer students each year.
2. The transfer application deadlines for Ivy League schools typically range from March 1 to April 1.
3. Transfer admissions criteria place little emphasis on college transcripts compared to high school records.

Chapter 24 | 24. Do You Need an Independent Counselor?| Quiz and Test

1. Independent college counselors are always more

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qualified than public high school counselors.

2.It is advisable to contact an independent counselor as early as eighth or ninth grade.

3.Independent counselors should write essays for their students to increase their chances of admission.

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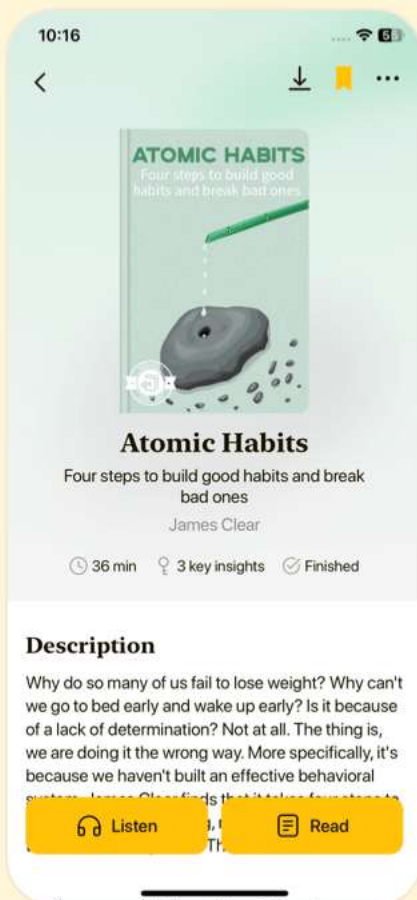


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Chapter 25 | 25. The Final Rung of the Ladder: Last-Minute Adjustments| Quiz and Test

- 1.Regional officers can thoroughly compare all students within their regions during the application reading process.
- 2.Docket review allows admissions officers to investigate discrepancies in admissions outcomes between students from the same high school.
- 3.Admissions offices are able to disclose specific details regarding rejected applicants to families who complain about the decision.

Chapter 26 | 26. Conclusion| Quiz and Test

- 1.The admissions process yields quality decisions despite being fallible.
- 2.The current Academic Index (AI) formula adequately considers students from diverse educational backgrounds.
- 3.A proposed change is to consider socioeconomic disadvantages in the admissions process.

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